

# The Decipherment of Scholastic Ogham

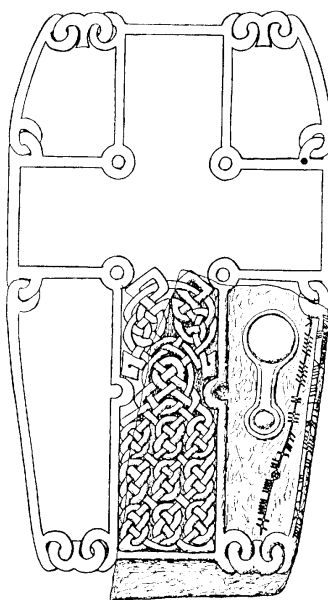
By

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Introduction

Abbreviations

Inscriptions



**Datab. No.:** 6000

**Site:** Formaston in Aboyne Parish, Aberdeenshire, Scotland

**Type:** Sepulchral

**Description:** A fragment of a broken cross, 29.5" tall by 13.5" at top, 16.5" at foot; 2" thick. The inscription is partly on and partly near the edge of a cross-slab found in the ruins of the mediæval church of Aboyne at Formaston, a mile east of the present village (according to Diack) in Aberdeenshire, Scotland. In 1892 it was located in Aboyne Castle. The stone is sculptured with a complicated plaited pattern and a mirror. The fragment is the bottom right half of a Christian Cross. When complete, it probably resembled the Glamis, Golspie and Scoonie stones, having an elaborately interlaced cross on one side and, perhaps, symbol-figures on the other. MacAlister considered the inscription a later addition to the stone, not made when the cross was carved, but after the fragment broke off. There are two lines of Ogham on the slab.

**Ogham Line 1:**   
**Transliteration:** MAQQOI TALLUORR(H)  
**Cognate Lang.:** Mæcg-oi Talorg  
**Translation:** (Belonging to) the son of Talorg,

**Comment:** All the inscription is preserved. According to MacAlister, it has every appearance of having been added later than the associated cross—probably after the stone had been reduced to its present fragmentary state. The cutting of the Ogham was less delicate than that of the associated symbols and the second line of the inscription had to be squeezed towards its latter end in order to get it into the space available—in a way that would have not been necessary had the stone been complete when the inscription was cut. Both lines read upwards, the initial line being on the left. At the end of the first line is a deeply cut slanting notch (read as 'H' by Jackson and MacAlister) which differs from the other scores and should not be taken as a letter according to MacAlister. It occurs between UORR and NEHHT (the first word of the next line). Both are known words, but in this case the slanting notch might indicate that UORR and NEHHT are to be read as one word (this reading originated with Rhys and Diack). In that case, the slanting notch would serve the purpose of an hyphen rather than being read H.

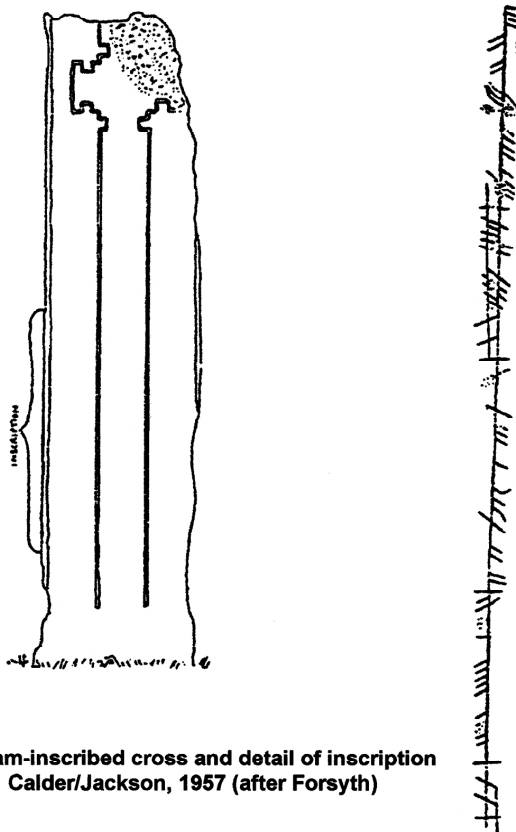
Jackson maintained that the so-called Pictish Ogham was not used as an alphabet in the conventional sense. MacAlister saw MAQQO-TALLUORR as a man's name, the son of the man named in the following line. MacAlister was uncertain whether to read the final stroke as an 'H' or as a mere "feathering." Diack read MAQQOTALL (Maqqo Tall) as the name Mac Táil (seen in early Irish documents; it means "son of the adze"—one who used the adze [tál] as a craftsman). Diack related UORR to Ur of the Pictish Chronicle (found in a series of names, such as Ur Pant, Ur Gnith, possibly id/w OI Úr = New, fresh; noble, generous (RIA U87). Brash and Nicholson saw it as MAQQOI TALLUORRH. Brash read it as Maqqoi Talluorrrh = "of the son of Talluorrrh." He quotes Skene who relates the name Talluorrrh to names found in the Pictish King-list: Talore, Talorg, Talloreen, and Talorgen. Brash pointed out that "Maqqoi" is a formula that appears in many Irish Ogham inscriptions. Nicholson read it as Mucoi Tall Mhoir = "of Maqqo Tall Mor." Nicholson felt that there may have been more of line 1 on the lost upper half of the stone. I do not agree. The Earl of Southesk read this portion of the inscription in 1886 as MAQQITALLUORRH = "(Stone) of the son of Talore." Note "Talore" in the Pictish King-list. Padel read MAQQOTALLUORRH. Forsyth read MAQQ(?)TALLUORRH. Ferguson felt that the H in Pictish represented an original G (noting the name INGEBORH = Ingeborg in the Stennis Runes). He therefore suggested that TALLUORRH = Talorg (a name on the Pictish King list).

**Vocabulary:** AS *Mæcg* = man, disciple, son (H224A). AS *Maga* = a son, descendant, young man, man (H228A). OI *Maccu* (*moccu*) = belonging to the family (gens) of (RIA M10). OI *Mac* (*macc*) = a son; a male descendant (RIA M5). AS *Tæl* (ON *Tal*, *tala*) = a tale, number, series; talk, parley, conversation; a talk, speech, oration (B968B; V624B). As regards UORR, we note Gaelic *Ur* = Person, child, infant (Dw998A), related to Gaelic *Urra* = person, infant; power, strength; chieftain; defendant at law (owner). OI *Úr* = fresh, new; fair, bright; noble, generous; a beginning (RIA U87ff). Also note Welsh *wyr* = grandson (E431B). Then there is OI *Úir* (*úr*) = mould, soil; grave (RIA U69), OI *Maccoim* = a boy, a lad (RIA M9), ON *Varr* (*vör*, *vart*) = cautious, wary (V681A), ON *Vargr* (AS *wearg*) = a wolf; an outlaw; a villain, a scoundrel, a criminal (B1177A; V680A). Greg Retallack of the University of Oregon, researching his own surname, had this to say: "The name is probably derived from *Talek* ... (which) in turn is most likely from the Old Cornish *talawg* meaning high forehead. The comparable Welsh name *Tallwch* and Pictish *Talorc* can be traced back to the 6th century." (Internet download Jan 2004)

**Conclusion:** Ferguson's view is appealing since I had independently noted that the Celtic H often appeared to represent a C/CH/GH/G sound (see my *Decipherment of SW Iberic*, 1992). Talorg could be identical with Talorg (also given as Talarg, Talorcan and Talargen) Mac Angus who reigned from 778-782 AD, but we also note Talorc (or Talorgan) son of Drostan who was described as "King of Atholl" in 739. It is also possible that he is merely a man with a similar name and the inscription could thus be later than the 8th century. It is clear that the inscription



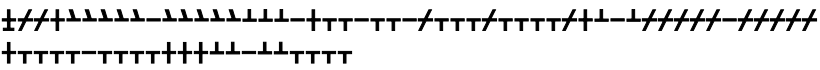
Bervie (Inverbervie or Bervie Bay) in Kincardineshire. In the late 19th century, Kinneff Manse (at or near Bervie) was occupied by the Rev. Thomas Brown. It would appear that Kinneff is quite an old place-name in the area in question. Thus, the entire Aboyne inscription reads: MAQQOITALLUORR(H)NEaHHTVROBBACCEaNNEVV = *Mæcg-oi Talorg, neachd bro'b a-Ceann-amh.* = Belonging to the son of Talorg, of an ancient family which was from Kinneff.



Ogham-inscribed cross and detail of inscription  
Calder/Jackson, 1957 (after Forsyth)

**Datab. No.:** 6001  
**Site:** Altyre, Morayshire, Scotland  
**Type:** Sepulchral

**Description:** Forsyth calls this "A tall, thin, Class III cross slab, sculpted in relief on two faces with crosses, having one ogham inscription incised vertically up one narrow edge and possibly another up the side of one cross-shaft." She went on to say that it was of grey sandstone, "approximately 3.3m tall from the current ground level, width 2'10" (0.86m), thickness 7" (0.18m)." She reported that the stone was severely weathered and covered in lichen. The ogham in some portions are worn and doubtful –and she suggested that there may be a portion missing from the very beginning of the inscription. Although the stone presently "stands surrounded by a wooden fence in a field by the drive from Altyre House to Forres, in the parish of Rafford, Moray," that is not its original position. It was apparently brought to Altyre about 1820 from another place.

**Ogham:**   
**Transliteration:** A MMAQQ TALLA(!)VA(!)N A(!) MAHHRR ASSUDDS  
**Cognate Lang.:** A mæcg Tallavan a mágr Asods.  
**Translation:** For the son of Tallava, by a kinsman of Assíd .

**Comment:** Jackson saw this as AMMAQQTALLV LV BAHHRASSUDDS, but his transcription in Fig. 14 of his book actually reads AMMAQQHA(or M?)HALLMBVBA(or M)M(or A)

HDDURABA(orM)LSUDDS... Padel saw AMMAQQ[A or T or Q]ALL[V or BL][B or L or V][L or V][M or B or A]AHHRASSUDDS. Katherine Stuart Forsyth reported extensively on this inscription in an unpublished PhD paper in 1996. Her version of the Ogham, based on an impression by Marianna Lines, is AMMAQQ(T/C?)A(LL/N?)MvsMAHHR( /a)R(a/aa/o)sSuDDS.

**Vocabulary:** AS A (ON á) = to, for; upon, in, by (B1B; V35Aff). AS *Mæcg* = man, disciple, son (H224A). AS *Mæg* (*mag*) -es = a relative, a kinsman; male kinsman, parent, son, brother, cousin; can also be a female relation, a wife (B654A; H224B). AS *Maga* = a son, descendant, young man, man (H228A). ON *Tala* = to talk, speak, record (V625A). ON *Van* (AS *wan*, *wana*) = a particle affixed to nouns and adverbs = deficient, lacking, short, under-; wanting, absent (V676A; B1164B). G *Assíd* (*aisíodh*) m. = a personal name (see below).

**Conclusion:** We note in *Gaelic Personal Names* by Donnchadh O'Corrain (p. 25, 1981) the name *Assíd* (*aisíodh*) (pronounced as'-i) = the name of the ancestors of the Meic Conmara (MacNamaras) who flourished in the 10th century AD --also borne by a king in Co. Clare who died in 1049. This suggests a date for this inscription at least as early as the 9th and as late as the 10th and 11th centuries AD. I tentatively suggest AMMAQQTALLA(!)VA(!)NA(!)MAHHRASSUDDS. I break it down as A MAQQ TALLAVAN A MAHHR ASSUDDS = A *mæcg Tallavan a mágr Asods* = For the son of Tallava, by a kinsman of Assíd.



**Auquhollie by Diego Meozzi**

**Datab. No.:** 6002

**Site:** Auquhollie, Kinkardineshire, Scotland

**Type:** Sepulchral

**Description:** Forsyth says: "A natural rectangular monolith, undressed and unshaped. The only carving is the ogham inscription up the south-east arris." She reports that it is "a quartzose gneiss ...highly stratified with frequent beds of quartz" and says that it is in good condition with some wear at the arris (carving sharpened in modern times). It is 2.35m tall, measuring 0.43 x 0.66 x 0.7m at the base. It stands 380m northwest of Nether Auquhollie farmstead in the parish of Fetteresso, 5 miles northwest of Stonehaven, Kinkardineshire. (Forsyth)

**Ogham:**                   TTTT+\*\*\*\*\*TTTTT+TTTTT[+\*\*\*\*\*]||||+\*\*\*\*\*||+TTTTT+[\*][TTTT]...  
**Transliteration:**       VINON[I]TE DOV U [L!].  
**Cognate Lang.:**       Winnanide dove—U(l)(aid?)  
**Translation:**         Winnanide sleeps—an U(l)(sterman?)

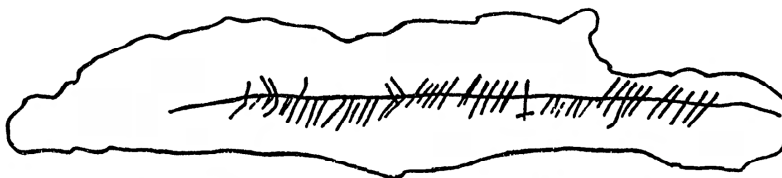
**Comment:** Nicholson read this VINONEHT TEDOV... = Vi Non e ht Tedov... = Ui Non àit Tedaibh = "O'Non's hearthside: 'Thieves.'" The Earl of Southesk personally examined the inscription on 1 May 1886 and saw F[A]DHDONANUITEN... = Faoidh Donan ui ten... = "Rests here Donan descendant of Ten..." Jackson saw VUUNON ITEDOV B. He gave no translation. Allen got VUONON(l)TEDOV. MacAlister got VUENON ITEDOVOR. Rhys visited the stone in 1891. He disagreed with the Earl's reading. He suggested VI (or UO)NON l?TEDOV—with a possibility that the final V might be followed by an l. Diack gave no reading of this inscription. It was too covered with lichen when he saw it. Padel reported it as VUUN(A or O)N(l)TEDOV(O or U) B-B. Katherine Stuart Forsyth reported extensively on this inscription in an unpublished PhD paper in 1996. She got VU(u/o)nON [?auoa/a(c/t)o?] TEDOV(u/o)(n/s)(i/e/r). Katherine Stuart Forsyth reported extensively on this inscription in an unpublished PhD paper in 1996.

**Vocabulary:** AS *Wyn(n)* (*wynna*, *wynnum*, *wynan?*) = Delight, pleasure; the best of its class, the pride of its kind; used as a name (B1285Aff). AS *Íde* = adj. easy, pleasant (B602A). Sc *Dover* (*dove*) = to slumber, to sleep; to be in a state between sleeping and waking (derived from ON *dofna* = to become dead (usually used for limbs—as when your foot "goes to sleep"—but it may have had a wider original meaning) (J II 91 AB; V101A). OI *Ulaid* = Ulstermen (an Ulsterman) (Ulster) (RIA U76).

**Conclusion:** I suggest VINONITE DOV U[L!]....? = *Winnanide* (*wynan-ide* = pleasant delight) dove U(l)(aid) = Winnanide sleeps—an U(l)(sterman?).



BIRSAY I - Rubbing of ogham inscription [Photo. Department of the Environment (Historic Scotland) No. A 2894-2, June 1971 (Crown Copyright)]



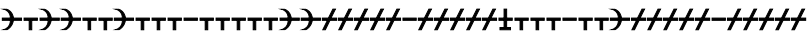
BIRSAY I - Ogham inscription [Padel 1972:56]

(These after Forsyth.)

**Datab. No.:**           6003  
**Site:**                Birsay I, Orkney, Scotland  
**Type:**              Sepulchral

**Description:** This inscribed stone was apparently reused as a building stone in an 11<sup>th</sup> century structure dubbed "Thorfinn's Palace." Forsyth describes it as "A squarish flag-stone inscribed along the narrow face ('the only really flat surface' [Padel 1972: 56] with an Ogham inscription." Its dimensions are 24½" x 12" x 4½". Its condition is "fragmentary, 'much chipped' [Padel MS notes]. According to Padel the stone has been broken and the two pieces cemented together."

Forsyth goes on to express her belief that the inscription was “most likely carved when in situ in a wall, rather than erected specifically to bear an inscription.”

**Ogham:**                      
**Transliteration:**        A BOL AV NORR AVLARR  
**Cognate Lang.:**        A' bö! æf Norre Aflar  
**Translation:**            The abode of a Norseman, Aflar.

**Comment:** Anthony Jackson reported this inscription as (M)ONNORRANNR (although he transcribed it as ABOLAVNORRAVLARR above!) and gave no translation. He noted the existence of a second inscribed stone at Birsay which was too fragmentary to interpret properly (he got BQI A B). Jackson reported that A.C. Thomas, on the basis of the carvings on the stone (*not the inscription*), regarded this as the "grave of a local sub-king of appropriate noble status, also a man of the elephant group and a man of the eagle group." Padel suggested (M)ONNORRA(LV or N)RR, but his *transcription* of the inscription shows ABO(BMV)NORRA(VV)RR (not far off from Jackson's rendition). Katherine Stuart Forsyth reported extensively on Birsay in an unpublished PhD paper in 1996. For Birsay I she got (m/h/a)ONNORRA(n/vv/lv)RR.

**Vocabulary:** G A' = Gen. & Dat. masc. (nom. & dat. fem.) of article: The (Dw1A). ON *Böl* (AS *botl*, *bolt*, *byld*) = to build (*böl* = built—very common in Danish local names and mark the lines of Scandinavian settlements); a farm, abode (espec. in Norway) (V74A). ON *Af* (AS *æf*) = prep. off, of, from, out of, beyond (belonging to) (B9A; V3Bff). ON Noregr (sounded Norre) = Norway. ON *Norrænn* (*norrcænn*; AS *norren*) = Norse, Norwegian; northern (usually of the wind) (B725A; V457B). N *Afl* = strength, physical force (V7A). AS *Lár* (ON *Lær*) = lore, teaching, instruction (B621A). AS *Láreów* = a teacher, master, preacher (B621B). Thus, *Aflar* could = strong teacher.

**Conclusion:** I will go with Jackson at this time. We need to see a good photo of this artifact. If, rather than "Norseman" the name Nora appears here, then the following is relevant: The name Honor (Honora), probably from the Latin = "honor," was current in the middle ages. The name Nora(h) is most simply explained as an abbreviation of "Honora." It was popular in Ireland after the Norman conquest, possibly because it bore a similarity to some Celtic name (it could even be from the Celtic version: *onoir* = honor). Thus, we can see that the presence of this name in a Celtic area in the latter part of the 11th century (the time of the Norman conquest), is quite logical (St201). Here again we would have a language reflecting a Teutonic population living in a Celtic environment. I get ABOLAVNORRAVLARR = A' bö! æf Norre Aflar = The abode of a Norseman, Aflar. In any case, my reading of the inscription supports Forsyth's finding that the stone was inscribed while part of a wall. Since it apparently refers to a Norseman, identifying the structure as his home, finding it in the wall of a purportedly Norse structure believed to date from the eleventh century is quite normal.







and Norse population. As mentioned above, *Nathdod* is believed identical with *Naddodd*, one of the discoverers of Iceland (circa ±860). The language is Old Norse, but affected by Celtic (note the Celtic spelling of "Cross," which in ON would be "Kross"). If this is indeed the daughter of the historic *Naddodd*, then this inscription must be dated to the latter part of the 9th century or the early part of the 10th century AD.

#### Ogham Line 2:

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 XXXXθ+++++

**Transliteration:** BENNRRES : MEQQ DD[RR!]OiANN

**Cognate Lang.:** Bænar's : Mæcg Treówan.

**Translation:** Belonging to Benir, the son of Droan.

**Comment:** Diack saw this as BERRISEst: MEQQ DDRROANN (he reads the Ogam C as an ST) = "Berrisest son of Mac Droan." Rhys saw this as BENNISES: MEQQDDRROANN = Wife of Mac Droan. Nicholson differed from Rhys on the second line. He got: BERNISES MEQQDDRDOANN = "-in Bernises (Battle-headland) of Mac Droian." MacAlister got: BENNIS: ES: MEQQ DDR{?}OANN. Together with the previous line, MacAlister read the full inscription as: "The cross of Dro, son of (the woman) Bennis, daughter of (the woman) Nahhtvddadd." Ferguson saw BENNR[P]ES: MEQQDDRROI ANN = bennres meqq droi ann. He pointed out that Nathdod (Naddodd) had a grandson, Benir. Dr. Graves and Brash both got BENNRRES:MEQQ DDRROiANN: (but Dr. Graves placed a colon after the Oi) = Benres of the sons of the Druid here." Padel read BENNISES: MEQQDDRROANN. Forsyth got BENiSESMEQQ DDROANN(-).

**Vocabulary:** ON *Bæn* (*bón*; pl. *bænar*; AS *bén*) = prayer, request, boon, entreaty (B83A; V91B). AS *Mæcg* = man, disciple, son (H224A). AS *Mæg* (*mag*) -es = a relative, a kinsman; male kinsman, parent, son, brother, cousin; can also be a female relation, a wife (B654A; H224B). AS *Maga* = a son, descendant, young man, man (H228A). AS *Treówan* (ON *Trúa*) = v. believe, trust; throw; to prove oneself true (n. faith, belief, trust) (B1014A; V642A).

**Conclusion:** From my study of the photo and Brash's drawing, I arrived at BENNRRES: MEQQ DDRROiANN = *Bænar's: Mæcg Treówan* = "Belonging to *Benir*, the son of *Droan*." As Ferguson points out, *Naddodd* is known to have had a grandson, *Benir*. Perhaps he was the child of *Anna* and *Droan*. Here again we have a Teutonic personal name with an ON possessive included in the same breath with what seems to be a Celtic form: MEQQ = *Mac* = son of. But is MEQQ Celtic? Note AS *Mæcg*, above. If this *Benir* is identical with *Naddod*'s grandson, then this inscription should be dated to some time in the 10th century AD. Thus, for the entire inscription on this stone I get: CRROSCC : NAHHTVDDADDS : DATTRR: ANNA BENNRRES : MEQQ DD[RR!]OiANN = *Crosg: Naddodds: dóttur: Anna. Bænar's: Mæcg Treówan.* = Cross of Naddodd's daughter, Anna. Belonging to Benir, the son of Droan.



"Rodney Stone," front and back Brodie Castle (from the Internet)

|                    |                              |
|--------------------|------------------------------|
| <b>Datab. No.:</b> | 6006                         |
| <b>Site:</b>       | Brodie, Morayshire, Scotland |
| <b>Type:</b>       | Sepulchral                   |

**Description:** A large class II symbol-inscribed cross-slab, sculptured in relief on both sides with ogham incised up three of the vertical edges. Of grey sandstone, it measures 1.8m (left) 1.905m (right); Width: 0.95m (top) 1.05m (bottom); Thickness: 0.1m. It is broken at the bottom with a portion missing. There is minor defacement due to modern re-use. Its face is badly weathered, but the carving on the reverse is well-preserved. The ogham is severely damaged and legible only in short snatches. (Forsyth)

### Ogham Line 1:

[illegible]

**Transliteration:** EDDARRNONILCIUDOVORRVITEOR  
(EDAR-NON ILCIUDO VOR VITEOR)

**Cognate Lang.:** Eidir-noin eald-cyððu for Vitra

**Translation:** Eidir-noin (of the old country?) for Vitra.

**Comment:** Also called the Dyke Stone or the Rodney Stone. It was discovered near Elgin. In 1898 it was located in Brodie Park, Morayshire. MacAlister points out that this inscription runs "in the peculiar retroverse Pictish way, up the right-hand angle and [the second line, covered in the next section] down the left." EDDARRNON is perfectly clear. This "word" also appears on the Fordoun and Newton stones in slightly different forms. MacAlister breaks this down as: EDDARRNON ILCIUOVORR VITEOR (provisionally: His-grave for-*Ilcuido Vite*) and continues with the following line. Rhys examined this stone in Sept. 1897. He got: EDDARRNONN[...] TAHUM:A(or O)... Earlier, in 1892, he got EDDARRNONN...TUMO... Wainwright said that one or two names found in the inscriptions of Pictland were recognizable as appearing in historical sources: "Such is the EDARNON of the Scoonie and Brodie stones and probably the IDARNONIN at Fordoun which seems to be the same as that of ETHERNAN or ITHERNAN, the founder and first bishop of Rathin in Buchan and of the Pict called ITHERNAN who died in 669 according to the Annals of Ulster and who may be the same person. It is apparently not Celtic." Diack broke the name down as follows: "We have here the stem IDO-, IDA-, seen in IDO-NATI (Greenloaning...) and IDD-AIQINN (Newton...), with the suffix -RNO- of adjectival force; cp. such names as LATH-AIRNE, MUG-AIRNE, Old Celtic UV-ARNA, a goddess. [Footnote: The

calendars of saints mention a St. ETHERNAN. This may be the anglicized form of EADHARNAN, but more likely from the stem ETR- seen in the Keiss Bay name ETRI.] In the present case the word is still further extended by the addition of the diminutive suffix -ON. Primitive *\*Idarnognos* would pass through *Idarnon*, *Edarnon* to modern *\*Eadharnan*." Padel got EDDARRNONN... (TT or UU)l... GNG... Padel regards MacAlister's reading as on the whole too fanciful to be worth considering seriously (but he quoted it anyhow for the sake of completeness). Incidentally, Padel reads this line last. Ferguson saw EDDARRNONNmeQ INgeNRRUNURBORH, equating it with *Eddarnonn meq ingen Rrunurborh* = *Eddarnon*, son of the daughter [lady] *Runurborh*. The Earl of Southesk saw EDDARRNON(N)(MAQ not seen, but supplied in a blank area by the Earl)Ql... His readings of the remainder of the Brodie inscription were quite incomplete. Forsyth saw EDDARRNON, but had no confidence in anything she could see thereafter. The inscription had apparently deteriorated too greatly by the time she saw it.

**Vocabulary:** OI *Eidir* = *Eighre* (*oigre*, *eiger*, *eigir*, *oigir*, *eidre*) = heir, inheritor, successor, descendant (RIA E79). AS *Eald-cyð* (*eald-cyððu*) = the old country (B227B). AS *For* (ON *fyrir*, *fyr*, *for*, *før*) = for, on account of, because of, with, by (before, in front of; at the head of; above; because of, for) (B301A; V180A). ON *Vitra* = wit, wisdom, sagacity (V713B).

**Conclusion:** I suggest that EDDARRNONILCIUDOVORRVITEOR could break down as follows EDAR-NON IL-CIUDO VOR VITEOR = *Eidir-noin eald-cyððu for Vitra* = *Eidir-noin* (of the old country?) for *Vitra*.

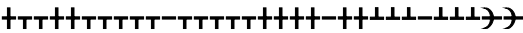
**Ogham Line 2:**        *+++++|++++|++++|+++|+---+---+---+|+|+|+|+>>+|+|+|+>>+|+|+|+|*  
**Transliteration:**    RAM IN[A O!]CC QOD TO SO[Ng!]S  
**Cognate Lang.:**     Ram inna ok quod to sangs.  
**Translation:**       He fought in battle and also sang songs.

**Comment:** This reads, according to MacAlister, from the top down. He breaks it down as follows: MADE OEVV IPENN GARIOZ = "this is(?) the stone of-the-nephew of Gariost." He admitted that his suggested translation for MADE was pure guesswork. It turns out, too, that he read this line downwards rather than upwards. Rhys, in Sept. 1897, got R(or F)AM(or G)MNAG ...HHTOHQO. Ferguson got EGNNUQQDIGACOLLUMBAN and equated this to the names Ecnecdach and Columbanus. Jackson got RGINNGCHQODTOSOMBS..., but his Ogham reads RAMSANNGH...H...QODTOSLMBS! Padel read this line as R (G or AM) INNgcHQODTOS (O or L) MBS... (sometimes one wonders if these folks are all looking at the same inscription!).

If MacAlister's downward reading is correct, MADE-Oi EVVllaEaNN GARIOZ probably should be MA[G!]E-Oi EVVllaEaNN GARIOZ = *Mæg-a (!) heófian Gár-es* = A kinsman is lamenting for a warrior. Note that the diphthongs *la* and *Ea* are essentially the same pronunciation. This scribe not only seems to have regarded them as the same, but also treats them as he treats 'internal' consonants—he doubles them. This would be nice, because it would confirm our view that EVVllaEaNN should be considered as one word EVIAN or EFIAN, giving us (H)E(O)FIAN! One should point out, however, that no other scholars have read this line in the downward direction nor have any seen the special characters (*Ea*, *la*, and *Oi*) that MacAlister purportedly saw. Therefore, this reading is highly suspect and probably should be disregarded.

**Vocabulary:** ON *Ramr* = strong, stark, mighty; vehement; bitter, biting; used in poetic compounds (a *ram-ðing*, for instance, is a battle or battle-meeting; as a coming together—or meeting—ramming in the sense of butting heads like two rams—it is possible that it could also stand for a battle) (V482A). AS *Ramm* (*ram*) = a ram; an instrument for pounding or battering; Aries (zodiac sign) (B786A). ON *Inna* = to do, perform (V314A). ON *Ok* = conj. and (V465Aff). ON *Kveða* (pret. *kvað*) (AS *cwedan*; 3rd. pers. *cweded*) (OE *quoth*) = to say; to sing (V360Bff; B178B). OSc *Quod* = quoth, said (J III 594A). OSc *To* = too (also) (J IV 588B). OSc *Sang* (*sangs*) = song (J IV 102A).

**Conclusion:** Following Padel and Rhys, I suggest RAMIN[AO!]<sup>CCQODTOSO</sup>[Ng!]<sup>S</sup>, breaking it down as RAM INA OCC QOD TO SONGS = *Ram inna ok quod to sangs* = He fought in battle and also sang songs.

**Ogham Line 3:**   
**Transliteration:** ALONN EO TTO  
**Cognate Lang.:** Alan heaw-to  
**Translation:** Moreover, Alan hewed (it). OR Grieve for Alan also.

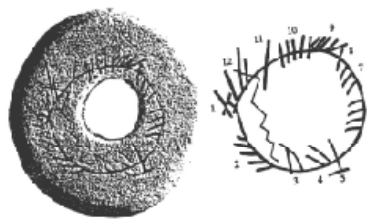
**Comment:** This inscription is on the cross-side of the stone. MacAlister has transliterated it, with some hesitancy, as VONSEODTO (remarking that the V could be an AL, giving ALONSEODTO). His anti-penultimate letter was unique, resembling the peculiar D seen on the Bressay stone with divergent curling tops to the scores, but here the curves spring from a single stem. We have seen on the Bressay stone that such a D could be a *ð*. Rhys, in Sept. 1897 got A(or I)LON(or B)..I(or O)MUTTO. Ferguson was unable to fix on a reading. Jackson showed it as VON...ECCO... Padel got (V or AL)ON... ECCO.

**Vocabulary:** *Al* (see *Eal*) = all (B33A). *Al(l)an*, *Allen* = a Celtic name of doubtful etymology (according to Withycombe), introduced into England at the time of the Norman Conquest (1066) (in French it was *Alain*); r.w. *Alanus* (Lat. for "fierce one") (according to Rule & Hammond) (RH39; W7). *Heawan* (*heaw*) = to hew, cut, cut down, kill, strike, make by hewing (H175A). *Heawen* = *Heofon* (H175A). Therefore, *Heawan* could be *Heofan* (to lament, grieve for) and *Heaw* could be *Heof* (wailing, mourning, grief) (H177). *Tó* prep. adv. = to, at, for, into (prep); too, also, besides, moreover, in addition (adv) (B989B; H342B).

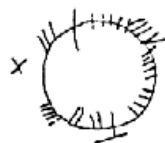
**Conclusion:** I tentatively suggest ALONNEOTTO = ALON EO TO = *Alan heaw-to* = Moreover, Alan hewed (it). Or, it could be "Grieve for Alan also." Perhaps this inscription was added at a later date—in which case the translation involving a lamentation is probably the correct one, but it is by a different carver than the earlier, for the spelling is different. If the name Alan does indeed exist on the stone, this is a means of dating it, for the name "Alan" apparently entered the British Isles with William the Conqueror in 1066. So, the total inscription reads: EDAR-NON ILCIUDO VOR VITEOR RAM INA OCC QUOD TO SONGS ALON EO TO = *Eidir-noin eald-cyððu for Vitra ram inna ok quod to sangs Alan heaw-to* = *Eidir-noin* (of the old country?) for Vitra—he fought in battle and also sang songs; moreover, Alan hewed (it) (or: grieve for Alan also).



Commercially available reproduction  
of the Buckquoy Spindle Whorl



Buckquoy — After Forsyth, 1996



Buckquoy (after Oliver J. Padel, 1972)  
(Cites Anthony Jackson)



Ogham-inscribed spindle whorl  
(first, or (see original for photo)  
(after Ritchie)

**Datab. No.:** 6007  
**Site:** Buckquoy, Orkney, Scotland  
**Type:** Sepulchral

**Description:** A chalk spindle-whorl incised on one face with ogham arranged around a circular stem. 'A fine-grained cream coloured sandy limestone, with quartz grains up to 0.5mm in diameter' [Collins 1977:222]. It is 36mm in diameter and 10mm thick. It is intact and in good condition. The inscription is well preserved. (Forsyth)

**Ogham:**   
**Transliteration:** NDD ACCAN I AV  
**Cognate Lang.:** Nydd Agan-i-æf  
**Translation:** I spin for Aggie (or Aggie's spinner).

**Comment:** This inscription is on a spindle whorl found by Dr. Anna Ritchie in the course of an archaeological investigation of what was believed to be a pre-Norse layer. The inscription is not around the edge (which makes it look like wheel ogham in the illustration by Padel), but actually on one face of the artifact. A small cross on the outside of the *fleasg* is to be used as a starting marker. Jackson (as reported by Padel) read it as (E)TMIQAVSALLC (he apparently read the "small cross" mentioned above as an E), but his transcription of the inscription in *The Symbol Stones of Scotland* appears to read TAIQANNALLQ. He also read it inverted as (E)(S or N)DDA(C or Q)TANIMV; but the inversion of TAIQANNALLQ should be NDDACCANIAV which might break down as: NDD ACCANI AV. Athy saw TMIQASSALLQ and without vowels, TMRQMSSMLLQ. He suggested an inversion: NDD MCC MNRMV. Athy recorded this as Birsay #3. He said it was on a spindle whorl found in the Orkneys. Katherine Stuart Forsyth reported extensively on this inscription in an unpublished PhD paper in 1996. She got ENDDACTANIM(V or L-B).

**Vocabulary:** C *Nedha* = to spin (*nedher* = spinner) (163A). W *Nyddaf* (OI *sniim*) = I spin (Jo135). W *Nyddu* (Irish *sni-* from IE *\*(s)ne-*) = to spin, twist (turn, wind) (Bu408:6.31; E346B; Walde-P. 9.694). OG *Agan* = precious, dear (Dw9A). *Aggie* is a pet form of *Agnes* (from the French *Agnès*, Latin *Agnes* = pure, chaste (the name was popular in the middle ages and it remained very popular up to the 17th century, but used in Scotland as late as the 20th century) (DuG6A).

**Conclusion:** I believe the inscription should be read counter-clockwise. I agree that the inscription is indeed inverted and suggest NDDACCANIAV (which is very clear from Padel's drawing of the inscription). Here the two nouns are Celtic, and the genitive of the name Agan (Precious, dear) is Celtic, but we seem to have the addition of the AS *æf* (of). The word *nyddu* is Welsh and relates to something which turns or spins. We note in later Scottish the word *nit* (nut) = wheel (of a crossbow) (this relates to our word 'nut' for something that turns on a bolt to fasten it) (J366Bff). Another possible translation holds closer to the Welsh: "I spin for Aggie" the *-an* ending would be an AS genitive, dative or accusative form for weak nouns.



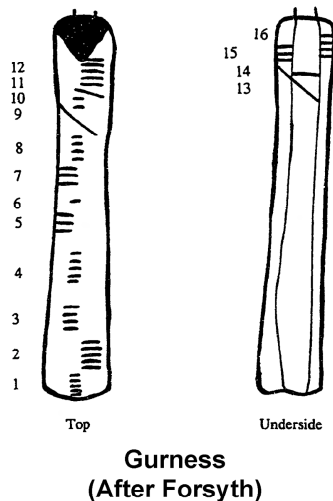




Plate on page 300 of The Scholar's Primer: *Auraicept na n-éces*, edited by George Carter). Bannerman got: iADDLADDORROLL ANSACITIRISIN = "Idols which abounded in this land." Unfortunately, Bannerman read it upside down. The Earl of Southesk got: ALLDALLDQQAADD MQQNUUFFHRRRIANN = Aildall Degad, son of Nur, (rests) here. In Brash's book it is given as HLLDMLLDQT(Ea or P)DDDMC(A?)CNQLFQ (ORS\*NN?). No attempt at translation is given in Brash. The initial character, which appears to be an H in some photos, was determined by the Earl to be a barred A. John Rhys read ALLHH(or D)ALLORREDDM(A)QQNUUVVA(or H)RREIRNg = Alhalor ed Mac Nuvar Irf = "Alhalor (raised the cross) for Mac Nuvar Irf." Nicholson saw: ALLHHALLORREDDM'QQNUUVVARRECCH = Alhallr, áit Mc Nu Uabharaich = "Alhallr, hearth of Mc Nu the Bold (or Proud)." Diack made a careful inspection of the stone and arrived at: ALLHHALLORREDDMEQQNUUVVANNE ...NN = Allcallorredd, son of MacNu" - "Uvan son of E...nn." MacAlister got: ALLHALLORREDDARRNAI VALARRENN. Padel read it as follows: ALLHHALLORREDDM(A or E)QQN(UU or I)V(Vor AL)(H or A)(R or N)RE(RR or NN). Forsyth got ALLHALLORREDDMeQQNiaVarrc(e?)rr.

**Vocabulary:** ALL-HALLORR = a personal name. ALL = ON *Al* (AS *Eal-*) = all, al-; perfectly, completely (prefix to a great many nouns and participles, answering to Latin *Omni*) (V11A) or ON *All* = very; an intensive prefix (V13B) plus HALLORR = ON *Hallr* (pl. *halir*) = a man, a hero—sometimes used of the dead inmates of Hel (V235B). EDD = *Ed* = ON *Ætt* = a family, a patrimony, property (V760A). MEQQ = OI *Mac* (gen. sg. *mec*, *meic*, *maicc*; AS *mæcg*) = son (a man) (B653B; RIA M5). NU = ON *Ny* (OI *nuá*, G *nuadh*) = the "new" of the moon (new, fresh, recent; a popular man's name pronounced rather like "Noah") (V459A). UVARR = *Ú-varr* (AS *un-wær*) = unwary, unaware, incautious, heedless, unprepared (B1135A; V666B). -ENN = *-en* = a termination of adjectives found in AS and ON (B250A; G312/163).

**Conclusion:** I suggest as one possibility ALLHALLORREDDMEQQNU-UVVARRENN = *All-hallr ed Mæcq Nuadha Ú-varr-en* = "All-hallr ('Perfect Hero') of the family of Mac Nuadha the Unwary." There is, however, another possibility that we must consider: The name Warren (surname and place name) stems from the French *Varenne*. It entered the British Isles with the Normans in 1066. We know that in the 13th century Reginald "of Waren" was in possession of certain lands in Scotland (see *The Surnames of Scotland* by Black). It is just possible that the family was present in Scotland at an earlier time as well. Thus, this *could* read: Allhallr of the family of Mac Nuadha of Warren. Gazetteers available to me reveal no such place name as Warren or Varenne in the British Isles, altho' Varenne in France is listed. According to the *Domesday Book*, William de Warrenne held Ditchling in lordship in Sussex shortly after 1066. If this is a reference to a family tied to Warrens it is obvious we have a mixture here: A Norse/Celt tied to a Norman family name. For this to be true, I suggest that this inscription can be no earlier than the 12th century (to give time for this kind of mixture to occur).



**Datab. No.:** 6010  
**Site:** Gurness Broch, Orkney, Scotland  
**Type:** Dedicatory

**Description:** This inscribed bone knife-handle was found in 1931 during the excavation of Gurness Broch, Aikerness, Orkney. Forsyth described the handle as 72mm long x 15mm wide x 12 mm thick. She reported that the inscription is "well-preserved and clear except for (a) small portion lost near (the) haft." The iron blade was "88mm long x 18mm wide x 6mm thick (max). There are two lines to the inscription, the longer being on one side and the name of the owner, in the possessive, on the other.

**Ogham:** ++++++-----+++++ [++ ] x /+++++  
**Transliteration:** INE ICCE M[O]N MATS [or INEITTEMEN MATS]  
**Cognate Lang.:** Inna eáca monni. Mat-s.  
**Translation:** For the birthing of a man. Belonging to Mattie (Maud).

**Comment:** The line of Ogham above incorporates line 2. MacAlister got INEITTEMON...MATS... and restored it: INEITTEM-ON MATS[...EN?] = "Of Mats...his ineittem" (whatever that tool might have been). Anthony Jackson recorded it as INEICTSMQUU EaM?CDE. Padel read it as INEITTEM (which he considered quite clear)EN M(A or O)TS. One of four readings suggested by Forsyth was IN(e/c)IT( /a)TEM(o/om/ob/u/e/? )N( /.)MATS.

**Vocabulary:** ON *Inna* = to do, perform (V314A). AS *Inna* = the womb (B594B). AS *Eáca -an* = an addition, an eking, increase (B224A). *Eácnian* = to increase, to become pregnant, to bring forth (B224A). AS *Mann (Monn)* = man, human being of either sex (B668B). MATS = poss. of MAT = ON *Matr* = might, strength (V419A).

**Conclusion:** I saw: INE I[CC!]E M[O]N MATS = Inna eáca monni. Mats. = For the birthing of a man. Belonging to Mattie (Maud). This knife apparently belonged to a midwife who used it to cut the cord at births. Note the pun between the ON *Inna* = to do, perform and the AS *Inna* = the womb. No doubt the ON *Inn* = within carried the same sense as AS *Inna*. The OG fem. name Mathild(is) (Mathilda) = mighty in battle (Du/G286Aff), was introduced into the British Isles in the 11th century by the wife of William the Conqueror. Note that the name MAT (in the possessive with S) is set off as important by a small "x." The normal spoken form of the name seems to have been Maud, but there could have been a form analogous to the known pet form for Matilda = Mattie. The appearance of this name suggests a date for this artifact of a time in the latter part of the 11th century. Here we have evidence that the Scots were already showing the demographics we see today: a Celtic people whose language has been strongly influenced by Anglo Saxon, Old Norse and even Norman French.







Ackergill - Photo by Royal Museum of Scotland  
Department of Archaeology

**Datab. No.:** 6012  
**Site:** Ackergill, Caithness, Scotland  
**Type:** Sepulchral

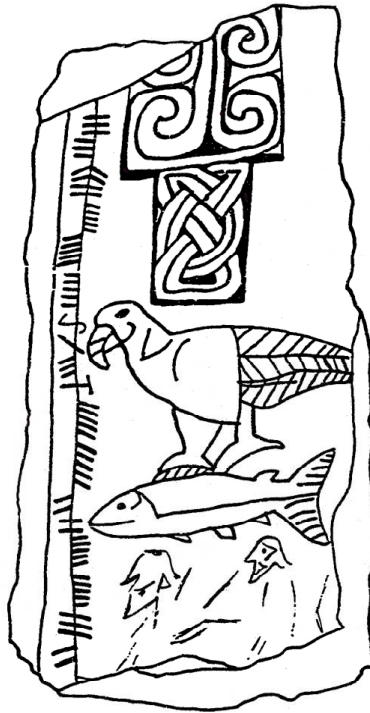
**Description:** A slab of Caithness slate, incised on one side with the remains of a pair of Pictish symbols and an ogham inscription. The slate is grey. The stone measures 1.20m tall x .60m wide x 0.08m thick. The various fragments of this slab have been cemented back together, but the surface of the upper part is missing, taking part of a symbol and perhaps part of the ogham with it. The remaining carving is clear and well-preserved. (Forsyth)

**Ogham:** TTTT+TTT+---TTT+TTT+TTT+TTT+TTT+TTT+  
**Transliteration:** NEHTETRI  
**Cognate Lang.:** Neachd edor-i  
**Translation:** Tribal enclosure (mausoleum? cemetery?)

**Comment:** The stone is said to have been originally sited by a long mound near Ackergill Tower in the parish of Wick. It was found broken in several pieces at Keiss Bay in 1896. Katherine Stuart Forsyth reported extensively on this inscription in an unpublished PhD paper in 1996. Allen, MacAlister, Diack, Cox and Rhys got the same reading: NEHTETRI. Rhys saw it in September 1897. Neither gave a translation, although Rhys made some suggestions (he broke it down as NEHTET RI...). Wainwright gave it as NEHTETRI, but could offer no translation. He was puzzled by the apparent presence of G alic forms but felt that the basic language was probably not Indo-European at all. Diack read NEHTETRI and broke it down as NEHT ETRI (although he also shows it as NEHTE TRI and supposed it to be incomplete). He suggested NEHT(E) might be nominative and reflect \**Neachd*.

**Vocabulary:** Old Gælic *Neachd* = Tribe, Family; Pledge (Dw686B). AS *Eador* (*edor*, *eder*) = a hedge, a fence, a place inclosed by a hedge, a fold; a dwelling, a house (enclosure) (B225B).

**Conclusion:** I also see NEHTETRI and, like Diack, break it down as NEHT ETRI = *Neachd edor-i* = "Tribal Enclosure" (where the enclosure is perhaps a cemetery area or, if translated as "house," the sense could be: "mausoleum"). The 'i' ending on *edor* may indicate a genitive.



Latheron  
(After Forsyth)

**Datab. No.:** 6013  
**Site:** Latheron, Sutherlandshire, Scotland  
**Type:** Sepulchral

**Description:** A cross-slab of local stone carved on one face with, one above the other, the ower part of a cross in relief, an incised bird and fish, and two incised horsemen. To the left is an incised ogham inscription. It is made of Caithness sandstone and measures 3' x 1'5" x 4". Its left edge is intact, all others fractured. Portions of unknown length have been lost from the top and bottom. The carving is worn, but generally clear. (Forsyth)

**Ogham:** 

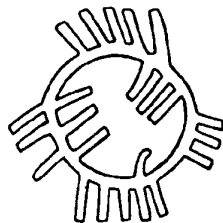
**Transliteration:** DUNNODNNATMAQQNAHHTO[N?]  
**Cognate Lang.:** Dún Oðin-naut mæg Neachtan.  
**Translation:** (Grave) mound of Oðin-naut, a kinsman of Neachtan.

**Comment:** This is on an Ogham-inscribed cross slab. Jackson recorded this as DUVNODNNA TMAQQNAHHTO... (but when he showed the purported Ogham, he gave it as DUVV OODNNATMAQQNAHATO...). He attempted no decipherment. Padel got DUV NODNNA(T or HH)MAQQNAH(H or A)TO. Wainwright suggested that the final word NETU[?] might have been a form of the known name, "Nehhton," the name of several Pictish kings. MacAlister read it as: DUNNODNNATMAQQNETU(OR?). The final two or more letters are anybody's guess since that

part of the inscription is missing. ON is probably as good a guess as OR—and so is simple R. Forsyth got DUnNODNNATMAQQNET(u). Forsyth's graphic shows a possible down-stroke below the first D indicating there may be a missing first word.

**Vocabulary:** AS *Dún* (*dúna*, *dúne*) = a mountain, a hill; a dune (mound); same meanings in Gaelic plus: fortress, castle; a fortified home or hill (B218B; Dw373B). G & OI *Od* = *ud*, *ut*. OI *udnacht* = a fence, a palisade —particularly one which marks an inviolable sanctuary. AS *Óðen* (*Wóden*; ON *Odin*) = one of the Teutonic deities (the word is found in place names) (B769A; B1261A). AS *Mæg* = relative, kinsman (male or female) (B654AB). Old Gælic *Neachd* = Tribe, Family; Pledge (Dw686B). OI *Neachtan* (*Neachtan*) = this is a female name in Irish legend, but note that *Nehhton* was the name of several Pictish kings; it is said to be cognate with "Neptune." (GPN144). The name *Neachtan* is probably composed of the above *Neachd* = tribe, family plus OG *On* = noble, excellent, good (Dw709B). ON *Nautr* = a mate, fellow; a person from whom a gift is received; a gift given by someone (V447A). So, *Oden-naut* = Gift of Odin. ON *Óðinn* (AS *Wodan*) = *Oðin* (the father of gods and men) (V470B).

**Conclusion:** I feel it could break down as: DUN ODNAT MAQQ NAHHTTO[N]. This *could* = *Dún* *Oðen-naut mæg Nehhton* = (Grave) mound of *Oðen-naut*, kinsman of *Neachtan* (where *Oðen-naut* is a proper name meaning "A gift from Odin" and *Neachtan* a proper name meaning "Of a Noble Family"). Here we see a mixture of Teutonic and Celtic name-forms. I must, however, point out another possibility: *Dún udnacht macc Nehhton* = Household (fenced) sanctuary (mausoleum?) of the Sons of *Neachtan*. Personally, I prefer the first version.



Logie Elphinstone Inscription  
Photo by Author

**Datab. No.:** 6014  
**Site:** Logie Elphinstone, Aberdeenshire, Scotland  
**Type:** Sepulchral  
**Description:** A painted pillar incised on one face with a pair of Pictish symbols, traces of a third, and ogham letters cut on a circular stem. The stone is of blue granite which may have been water-worn before carving. It measures 1.37 x 0.76 x 0.45 m. Its condition is good. The carving is intact and well-preserved. (Forsyth)

**Ogham:** ++++++  
**Transliteration:** CALTHATBHO  
**Cognate Lang.:** Cwæld Haðu-be  
**Translation:** Slain in war.

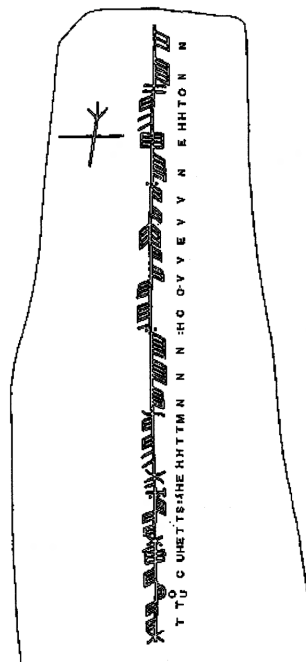
**Comment:** It is also called the Carden Stone. According to Diack, this is the only known example of 'wheel ogham,' where a circle is used as a stem-line. He held that the reading is from the right to left (as shown by the slope of the scores—besides, that direction is the only 'lucky' one). The beginning, he held, is at the empty space in the top left hand corner (at no other point can one get an intelligible reading). The scores are in good condition and, except for one difficulty, everything is clear. Diack got CALTBHO,



which he held to be the adjectival formation in the nominative case on the stem *Calti-*. The ending *-bho* can be seen on the Newton Stone, according to Diack (*Cingono-vo*). He said that it meant "descended from *Caltis* (or 'The *Caltian*')." The Earl of Southesk read *ATHAT BHOTO*. Rhys read *CALT HADBHO* (or *CABATHADBHO*) (no translation given). Moore saw *OBHEN? PETHECH*. Ferguson got *TOGTUCH*. Nicholson saw *OVOBHVAHTA*. E.C.M. got *CALTCAHO* or *CABATCAHO*. Diack got *CALTIBHO*. MacAlister felt that this inscription was interesting as "being perhaps an example of the magical use of Ogham, but it has no assignable meaning." Padel commented that the inscription was quite clear and gave a number of possible readings. His preferred reading was *DDALTQ* (or *QUDDALT* since he elsewhere correctly pointed out that scholastic ogham tends not to use a double consonant in an initial position). Forsyth commented at length on this inscription and discussed Padel's findings (and listed others'), but gave no reading of her own.

**Vocabulary:** *AS Cwæl (cwelan)* = died (B176A). *AS Cwalu* = a quelling with weapons; torment, a violent death (B176A). *AS Cwelan* = to die (be slain, killed) (B177A). *AS Cwellan (ic cwele; ðu cwelest, cwelst; he cweleð, cwælð)* = to kill, slay (B177A). *AS Heaðu (heaðo)* = war (occurring only in compounds; as *hōð* and as *haðu* found in some Teutonic proper names) (B523B). *AS Be* = at, in, on, near to, to; of, from, about (B69A).

**Conclusion:** Working from my own photos (made in 1987) and MacAlister's drawing, I get (like Rhys): *CALTHATBHO* = *CALT HATBHO* = *AS Cwælð Haðu-be* = "Slain in war."



(Allen/Anderson, 1903)  
(After CISP Database Website.)

|                     |                                                                                                                                                                            |
|---------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Datab. No.:</b>  | 6015                                                                                                                                                                       |
| <b>Site:</b>        | Lunnasting, Shetland, Scotland                                                                                                                                             |
| <b>Type:</b>        | Sepulchral                                                                                                                                                                 |
| <b>Description:</b> | It has been described as a flat stone shaped somewhat like a coffin lid, 3 feet 8.5 inches long, 13 inches wide, and 1.5 inches thick. Forsyth was a bit more accurate. It |







Newton Stone (Uncial). Photos by Author.  
(Computer-enhanced)

**Datab. No.:** 6016  
**Site:** Newton, Aberdeenshire, Scotland  
**Type:** Sepulchral

**Description:** The Earl of Southesk reported it as “an unhewn dark grey boulder of gneiss bearing on and near its left angle two lines of Oghams and on its face an inscription in debased Greek [actually Irish uncial] characters.” It stands in a lawn with another stone (uninscribed) beside Newton House, a few miles from Inverurie, in Aberdeenshire. It was visited and extensively photographed by the author in 1987. Forsyth described it as follows: An irregular, ridged pillar incised at the top of one face with six lines of (?pseudo-)alphabetic characters, and down the left-hand edge with an ogham inscription. It is a grey, gneissose granite measuring c.2.09 x 0.70 x 0.40 m [ECMS] = c.2.03 x 0.84 x 0.53 m. Its conditions is complete. Its carving is very well preserved. (Forsyth)

**Uncial Lines 1-3:** **ÆTTÆ ÆUAGAINNIAS CIGONOVOCO**  
**[One character above is incorrect; computer font is corrupt: the o.]**  
**Transliteration:** ETTE EUAGAINNIAS CIGONOVOCOI  
**Cognate Lang.:** Æt-eówigan-as ci go Novo-coi.  
**Translation:** To show mourning for Novus [Nuadha] the Protector.

**Comment:** This stone has also been called the Shevack Stone. Scholars usually say that these characters are debased Roman or Græco-Roman (even Byzantine) letters in an uncial form following the Celtic type. Francis Diack read it: ETTE EVAGAINNIAS CIGONOVOCOI. He saw *Ette* as a nom. sg. m. prop. name of the e- (i-) declension. He noted place names in Argyle beginning with *éit-* or *et* as well as the woman's name, *Ete*, in the Book of the Deer. He saw *Evagainnias* as the genitive of a woman's name, comparing it to names like *Evacattos* and *Evolenggi*. He saw *Cigonovo* as a form of *Cingonovo*, another name. The stem, *cing*, is prolific in old Celtic personal names. He saw *Cingono-vo* as the nom. sg. m. of a compound, the second element, *vo*, being for an older *vos* = “descendant of,” seen in the genitive in an Ogam in Wales: *Cunacenni-vi*. The last word, *coi*, he saw as an adv. meaning “here” or “here lies.” So, he got: “*Ette*, son of *Evagainnias*, Descendant of *Cingo*, (lies) here.” Nicholson saw ÆTTÆ ÆCUNVAUR C(um)VONOBOTO = *àite 'Ic Nun Vaur cum bono voto* = “Hearthside of Mac Nun Vor”. Rys saw ÆTTÆ ÆCUNVAVR... and got *Kin Ecnun Vaur*... The Earl of Southesk saw ETTE FURYRIAGS GYOLOUOCÆ or possibly AITTAI FURUR-INGIN SUOLOUOSE and got: *Eté, Forar's* daughter, of the race of the sons of *Uos*. Samuel Ferguson saw the word at the

beginning as FTTF —as a monogram; the second word as *Furtrinn Rex*; and the third, *Gito ho loco* with a sign of contraction over the *ho*. He regarded the language as Latin. His implied translation would thus be: "FTTF, King of *Fortren* (Pictland).... William Bannerman saw ETTE CUNANMAIN MAOLOUOEG. He read this as Old Gælic *Ito ad animam Moloci* = "Draw near to the soul of Moluag." This refers to St. Moluag who built a church on an island in the Firth of Lorn (mentioned, according to Bannerman, in the next portion of the inscription). Bannerman pointed out that this form of 'E' and 'C' were strikingly similar. L.A. Waddell saw this as KaZZI KaST.SiLUYRi GYaOLOWONIE = "This cross *Qas* of the *Silur* (sub-clan) of the *Khilani*..." He read the characters as Phoenician script and the language as Semitic, being bi-lingual with the Ogam which was in Celtic. Forsyth discussed the uncial inscriptions on this stone and quoted Brash, Ferguson, Diack, and Browne. She gave no reading of her own for the uncial.

**Vocabulary:** AS *Æt* = prep. To, unto, before, next (B20B). *Æt-eówian* (-eówigan) = to show, manifest, display, declare; to appear (B21A). *Æt-éwung* = f. a showing, manifesting, epiphany (B21A). AS -As (ON -s) = genitive termination on Masc. or Neut. nouns (problem here is that *æt-éwung* is Fem.) (M59). OG *Ci* = lamentation; to lament, wail, weep (mourn) (Dw191B). G *Go* = to, toward; that, to the end that (Dw5309AB). G *Nuadh* (L *novus*; *novio*;- ON *nyr*; AS *níwe* from IE *\*newo-*) = new, fresh, recent, modern, unused (young, novel) (Bu957; C397B; Dw700B). G *Coimh* = OG *Comh* = to preserve, keep (protect, guard) (Dw236A). OG *Cu* = champion, hero (Dw283B).

**Conclusion:** I agree that the first word is composed of a vowel-consonant-consonant-vowel combination, most probably ETTE. I suggest: ETTE EUAGAINNIAS CIGONOVOCO = *Æt-eówigan-as Ci go Novo-coi* = "To show mourning for *Novus* the Protector." In my opinion, *Novus* is the Latin form of the Celtic name, *Nuadha* (pronounced, *No-a* or *Noah*). O'Rahilly suggested that *Nuadha* means "cloud-maker," and others have their own derivations, but I believe that my derivation is correct.

**Uncial Lines 4-6:**   
**Transliteration:** UR (Filfot) RELISI MAQQI NOVIOGRUTR  
**Cognate Lang.:** Ûir \*Reil-ise mæg-i Nuadha-grytr  
**ation:** Grave of \*Reil-ise ["she is a star"], wife [or "female relation"] of Nuadha Gryt(r) ["Novus the Great"]

**Comment:** Diack saw this as URAELISI MAQQI NOVIOGRUTA = "The grave of Elisios, son of New Grus." Ferguson's reading (as given by Forsyth) is so off the mark it doesn't bear repeating.

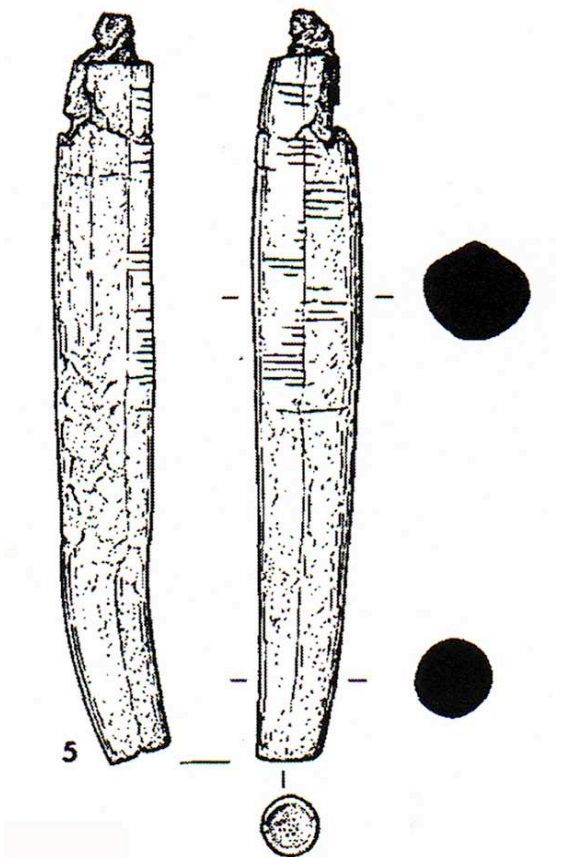
**Vocabulary:** G *Ûir* = mound, grave; mould, dust, earth, soil (Dw994A). G *Reil* = gen. sg. of *reul* (Dw753B). G *Reul* = star (Dw755B). G *Reulag* = little star; starry, astral. (Dw755B) G *ise* = pers. pn. emphatic of *i*: she, herself (Dw558A). AS *Mæcg* = man, disciple, son (H224A). AS *Mæg* (*mag*) -es = a relative, a kinsman; male kinsman, parent, son, brother, cousin; can also be a female relation, a wife (B654A; H224B). AS *Maga* = a son, descendant, young man, man (H228A). G *Nuadh* (L *novus*; *novio*;- ON *nyr*; AS *níwe* from IE *\*newo-*) = new, fresh, recent, modern, unused (young, novel) (Bu957; C397B; Dw700B). AS *Greát* (mod. Scott. *grit*, *gryt*, *gret*) = great, large, big, thick, gross, coarse, swelled, in a state of pregnancy (B487B; J455A). Lett. *Gruta* (IE *\*gwrū*) = heavy (used in sense "heavy with child") (Buck284B; W/P 1.684ff).

**Conclusion:** I get: UR (Filfot) RELISI MAQQI NOVIOGRUTR = Ûir \*Reil-ise mæg-i Nuadha-grytr = Grave of \*Reil-ise ["she is a star"], wife [or "female relation"] of Nuadha-Gryt(r) ["Novus the Great"]. I am of the opinion that the "filfot" or "swastika" is here a non-alphabetic symbol intended to set off an important personal name. *Novus* (Celtic *Nuadh*, AS *Níwe*) is a not unusual man's name. *Grutr* would seem to be a form of "great" (large, gross, great) similar in form to the Lett. *gruta* (heavy) (but which might be carrying a pronunciation approaching the modern Scottish *gryt*) which would seem to go back to the same IE root *\*gwrū*.



novel) (Bu957; C397B; Dw700B). F *Reine* = Queen (Harr719Bff). F *Regn* = reign; kingdom (Harr718B) (IE \**reg-* Walde P 2.362ff). AS *Reccend* = a ruler, governor (applied to the Deity; also used for earthly rulers) (B788B). ON *Regin* = the Gods (rulers—in the sense of Rulers of the universe); used with proper names to mean "holy" and "mighty;" the Saxon name *Reyn-olds* and others which came from this word show an AS pronunciation of *Reyn* or *Ren* (V488B). AS *Eua* = Eve, Eva (from the Latin) (B261B). AS *Róse* (ON *rós*) = a rose (B802B; V503A). OI *Éva*, *Éba*, *Éabha* = in Irish tradition was one of the wives of Nemed, legendary invader of Ireland (GPN90). OI *Róis*, *Róise*, *Rós* = appears to derive from OGerm *hros* (horse) though at an early period it was identified with the flower of that name. It was brought into England by the Normans and reached Ireland much later.

**Conclusion:** After studying photos I took of the stone in 1987, I suggest IDDAI QNN NVORRENI Ea[UA] [R!]<sup>1</sup>OSIZ = *Ætt cwén Novo [Nuadha] Regin Eva-róse is* = [This] is for the wife of mighty Nuadha, Eva-Rosa. The names are Celtic, but the use of "Rose" suggests an 11th century or later date for this inscription because that name was brought to the British isles by the Normans in 1066. It is important to note that Nuadha (Novo = Novus) is also mentioned in the uncial inscription on the same stone, wherein his wife is called by a different name. He appears to have had two wives. The memorial is for all three, perhaps in the following order: Eva-Rosa (perhaps the first wife —and the first to die), followed by Nuadha and Reil-ise (probably in that order).

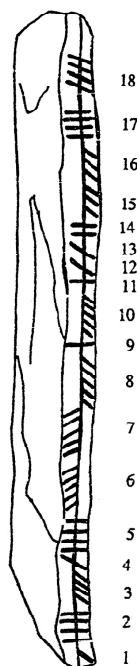


Whale-bone Knife Handle, Bac Mhic Connain  
(Society of Antiquaries of Scotland, 1994)

|                    |                                        |
|--------------------|----------------------------------------|
| <b>Datab. No.:</b> | 6017                                   |
| <b>Site:</b>       | Bac Mhic Connain, North Uist, Scotland |
| <b>Type:</b>       | Dedicatory                             |







St. Ninians  
(after Forsyth)

**Datab. No.:** 6018  
**Site:** Parish of Dunrossness, St. Ninian's, Shetland, Scotland  
**Type:** Sepulchral

**Description:** Forsyth reported: "Following a careful search in July 1876 this ogham-inscribed slab was found by the Shetland antiquarian Gilbert Goudie 'imbedded in the sand'. He presented it to the National Antiquities Museum in 1877 (NMS Cat. No. IB112)." It was reportedly found on the shore of St. Ninian's, a small islet in the Shetlands. She described it as "A carefully prepared, thin, oblong slab, undecorated except for an ogham inscription carved up the entire length of one narrow edge." Made of lightly colored sandstone, it measures 760mm long x 265mm broad x 45mm thick. The two broad faces are severely laminated and large chunks of the surface have been lost. Both the upper and lower edges are fractured. A portion of unspecified length is missing from the beginning of th edge, but the inscription is otherwise well-preserved. (Forsyth)

**Ogham Line:**   
**Transliteration:** BESMEQQNANAMMOVVEZ  
**Cognate Lang.:** Besih mæcg ná-námo wæs.  
**Translation:** Behold! An un-named man was he!

**Comment:** Rhys saw B (or L or V or S or N) ESMEQQNANAMM (or G) OVVEZ (Rhys transcribed this Z as an F). Goudie, Ferguson and Brash got ...ESMEQQNA NAMMOFFEST while the Earl of Southesk got ...ESMEQQNANAGOFFEST. Nicholson arrived at LESMEQQ NANAMMOVVEST. MacAlister got LESMEQQNANAMMOVVEZ. Padel and I both got BESMEQQNANAMMOVVE Z. Forsyth got -b']ESMEQQNANNAMMOVVESr.

**Vocabulary:** AS *Be-sih* = Look! Behold! (B91A). AS *Mæcg* = man, disciple, son (H224A). AS *Ná*, *nó* = No, not (B705B). AS *Náma* (ON *nafn*; OSax *namo*) = m. a name (B708B). AS *Wæs* = 3rd per. sg. of *wæsan* (verb "to be") = (he/she/it) was (B1209B).

**Conclusion:** I break it down as BES MEQQ NA NAMMO VVEZ. = *Besih mæcg ná-námo wæs* = Behold! An un-named man was he!



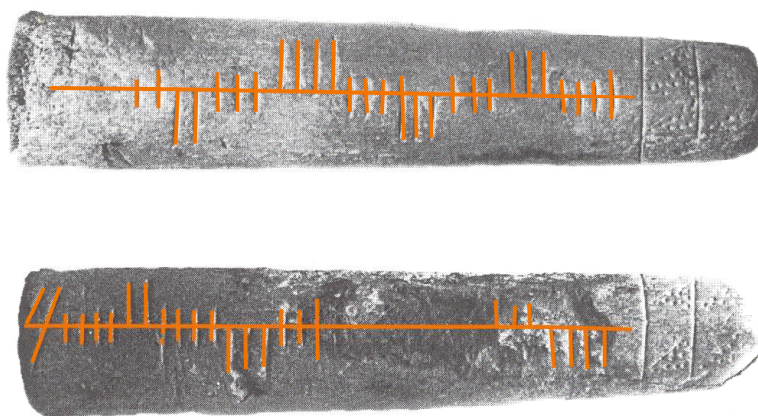


first letter which he believes to have been an E, but which he agrees could be an I. Study of the photo leads me to believe that Rhys' reading of the HT is incorrect. It is clearly DD. MacAlister conjectured that there had been more to the inscription that is now lost due to wear and breakage. Forsyth got EDDARRNONN.

#### Vocabulary:

OI *Eidir* = *Eighre* (*oigre*, *eiger*, *eigir*, *oigir*, *eidre*) = heir, inheritor, successor, descendant (RIA E79). OI *nán* = small, dwarfish (RIA N13).

**Conclusion:** In the photo I took in 1987, I see UDDARRNONN, with the probability that one or two strokes are missing from the first letter, giving us EDDARRNONN (or IDDARRNONN) as suspected by others. Also, in the photograph, the first two strokes of the first N appear to cross the center line and join at the top giving us O, which would make the other three strokes equal to V, thus EDDARRVONN. On the whole, however, I prefer EDDARRNONN since that group also appears on the Brodie Stone. It is possible that it could break it down as follows: EDD-ARR-N-ONN. The letter N is normally placed between the possessive pronoun, *Ar* = Our (Dw42B) and the following noun when that noun begins with a vowel. I contend, however, that since the convention seems to be that a new word starts with a single consonant while medial consonants within a word are doubled, it should break down as EDDAR-NONN (EDAR-NON). I suggest: EDDAR-NONN = EDAR-NON = *Eadhar-nan* = *Eidir-nan*, a personal name: "small heir." The same name may be seen in a slightly different form in the Fordoun inscription (#6023).



Weeting knife-handle, computer enhanced

**Datab. No.:** 6020  
**Site:** Weeting, Norfolkshire, Scotland  
**Type:** Dedicatory  
**Description:** At this time I have been unable to locate descriptive material pertaining to this inscription. So far as I have been able to determine, Forsyth does not discuss it (unless she knows it under another name). Jackson mentions it, but does not appear to describe it.

**Ogham Line 1:** ++++++-----+-----+-----+-----+-----+  
**Transliteration:** EVVTUSUDU  
**Cognate Lang.:** Af Tosti (?)  
**Translation:** Belonging to Tostig (?)

**Comment:** This is on one side of a knife handle made from deer antler. Both sides are inscribed. Jackson transliterated this side as ULUCUVUTE, but his ogham shows VLVEVVTTE. Clarke got (U)LUCUVUTE. Padel got ULUCUVUTE in one direction (towards the blade) and EVUTUSUDU in the other. Athy stated that the knife bore two relatively short Ogam inscriptions, but since they did not comply with the formulæ of the



included here are not in Ogham, we include them because it is clear from the Newton Stone that the carvers of the Ogham inscriptions in Scotland used Uncial as well. Thus, studying one, uncial or ogham, can elucidate the others.

Diack saw DROSTEN IPEUORET ETTFOR CUS and got: Drosten. *I(n) p(ac)e Uoret ett Forcus*. He says that *Drosten* is the diminutive of *Drost* (both names being well-known in Pictland). According to him, *Uoret* is a compound—perhas *Vor-ette* (the second part being the ETTE of the Newton Stone. He claims that FORCUS has no connection with *Fergus* in which the G is aspirated, but is *Forgus* (Irish Ogam *Vorgoso* [gen.] nom. \**Vorgis*, later *Forggus*, *Forcus*. Diack placed the date in the 8th or 9th century AD (it must be later than the 7th, for the original v has become F in *Forcus*). MacAlister read this as DROSTEN IPEUOR ETETTFOR CUS = "A cross for Etett, nephew of Drost." He suggests that ETETTFOR might be another way of spelling the ITEDOVOR which he sees on the Auquhollie Stone. Rys saw this as DROSTEN-IPE UORET ETT FORCUS, where *Drosten* is the genitive of a man's name, *Drost*, depending on *ipe*, "which is placed after it, not before it, as one might expect had the legend been any kind of Celtic." He thinks that IPE might mean "boy" or "nephew," but hardly "son," as *Drost*, so far as we know, was only a man's name and paternity was not supposed to have been recognized in Pictish descent, but birth alone. He takes ETT to be Latin *et*, intended to be read for the native Pictish word for "and" (just as occurs in some Irish inscriptions where *et* is used in place of *ocus*) to be equated with the EDD on the Golspie Stone. Rhys suggests: "Drost's nephew, Uoret and Fergus." While *Forcus* (*Fergus*) is Goidelic Irish, he suggests that *Uoret* is probably native and matches the Pictish King *Wrad* who was reigning about 839-844. Forsyth does not discuss this stone, perhaps because no ogham was present.

### Vocabulary:

Welsh *Ap* (*ab*) = son of (ET1A) (it is my opinion that IP or IPE might = *ip*, a form of the Welsh *Ap* (*ab*) = son of (E1A), a component of so many Welsh surnames (Ap Ross, etc) (see IP on the Greenloaning Stone). *Uoret* could be a form of ON *Vörð* = a woman under tutelage, a wife (V722B). George F. Black in *The Surnames of Scotland* discusses the male name, *Fergus* (*Feargus*), and traces it to Old Irish. He states that the name is cognate with Cymric *Gwr-gwst*, Old Breton *Uuorgost*, and Pictish *Forcus*. He specifically states that "The Pictish form is also found on the inscribed monument at St. Vigeans in Angus." He adds that in the list of Pictish kings it is also written *Urguist*, *wirguist*, and *Wrguist*. It means "super choice" from \**Ver-gustu-s*. While I still prefer my reading, I must note that the portion of the inscription that reads EVORET could be a form of the modern Everett (Everard, Evered) --root-word OE *eofor-raed* = "Boar Counselor" (figuratively, "Stalwart Counselor") (some trace it to the ancient Germanic name *Eberhard(t)* = "Wild boar and brave, hardy or strong." It has been suggested that the name arrived from the continent at the time of the Norman conquest. Others feel it may have swallowed up an unattested Old English cognate, *Eoforheard*.

**Conclusion:** Every letter is certain except for the O in ETTFOR-. It is uncertain whether it is an O or an E. I prefer to read it Æ. I suggest that IP or IPE might be a form of the Welsh *Ap* (*ab*) = son of (E1A), a component of so many Welsh surnames (Ap Ross, etc) (see IP on the Greenloaning Stone). I get: DROSTEN IPEVORET ETTFÆR CUS = *Drosten, ipe Voret et Færgus* = Drosten, the son of Voret and Fergus. There were several Pictish kings named Drost. One, whose parents are not named in the source available to me, reigned c. 724-726 AD. Note that the king who reigned from 729 was a son of Fergus (perhaps Drost's brother?). There was a good deal of fighting over the succession to the throne in that period and it was probably brothers who were doing the squabbling. This reading, of course, demands that *Uoret* or *Voret* be a woman's name. Note that her name is given first, as would be logical in the Pictish society which traced the lines principally through the woman.

I still prefer my reading, but if the name Everett does indeed appear, then the inscription might read: DROSTEN IP EVORET ETT FOERGUS = Drosten, ip Everet, et Fergus = Drosten, the son of Everett, and Fergus. This would mean the inscription commemorates TWO persons.



Fig. 2. The Greenloaning Stone. (From a photograph by Messrs Croxall & Rodger, Stirling.)

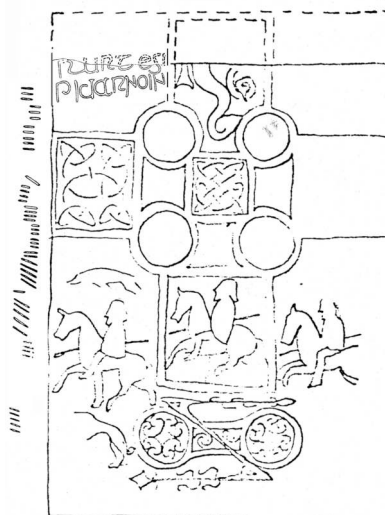
|                         |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|-------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Datab. No.:</b>      | 6022                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| <b>Site:</b>            | Greenloaning, Perthshire, Scotland                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| <b>Type:</b>            | Sepulchral                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| <b>Description:</b>     | Also known as the Roundel Stone or the Greenloaning Stone. It is a dioritic slab 4 feet high, 3 feet wide and 9 inches thick. This incorporates lines 1, 2 & 3 (line 1 only contains the IP). The lettering was uncial, in a form slightly different from the uncials shown above. The stone was found in Townhead, Greenloaning, near Ardoch, Perthshire (about 11 miles north of Stirling). In 1898 it was at the Smith Institute in Stirling. |
| <b>Uncial Line:</b>     | IP BVAH QATTI DONAT[TI] VERGAMEBO NO[TI]VO                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| <b>Transliteration:</b> | IP BVAH QATTI DONATI VERGAMEBO NOTIVO                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| <b>Cognate Lang.:</b>   | Ip Buadha Catti donati—Vergamebo notivo.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| <b>Translation:</b>     | (Stone) of the son of Buadha of the Catti, Donatus [A Gift]—Vergameb wrote (on it).                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |

**Comment:** Nicholson read the two lines of this inscription as BVAH QATT IDON AIT and VURCAMU BONOIT NO. Rhys disagreed. He eliminated BVAH as no part of the original—as well as the IP and other markings which could be seen outside of these lines. He felt that these were added later. He noted that the T in DONAT had a line attached at its top indicating a TI reading. Diack discounted the existence of the "IP," seeing it as "II." The other two lines he read as BVAHQATTIIDONATI VERGAMEBO NOTVO. He regarded the language as Old Celtic "of the early centuries of our era." Rhys suggested QATTI DONATI = "Cat, (son of) Donatus." The third line, located further down the stone, Rhys felt was a completely separate inscription, although possibly cut by the same hand as the one above. He read the lowest line as: VERGAMEBO NOTIVO. He translated the whole as "(The gift) of Qatt and Donat to Vergameb (and) Notiu." Rhys equated the EB in EBO with such Pictish names as *Ythernbuthib* and *Bergib* (the -O being a dative ending). MacAlister felt that this stone was not Pictish, but very early Celtic. He did not see the IP. He felt that the BUAH represented someone's initials and played no part in the inscription. He recorded the two main lines as: BVAHQATTI DONAT† (Rhys's combined TI is here recorded as a cross: †) VIIRSAMIIBONO†VO (or VIIRSAMMIIBONOTVO). Other markings on the stone he interpreted as possible 'crypt-runes' and 'cabalistic' characters,' which, along with others, he

dismisses as being of doubtful antiquity. He gave no translation. So far as I have been able to determine, Forsyth does not mention the Greenloaning inscription.

**Vocabulary:** *Ip* = Welsh *Ap* (*ab*) = son of (E1A). OG *Buadha* = Precious (Dw133B). Latin *Donatio* (*-onis*) (Welsh *dawn* or OWelsh *doniad*) = a giving, a donation, a gift (C202A; E164B/194A). AS *Weorc* (ON *virki*, *verk*) = work, labour (B1191A; V710B). AS *Ambeht* = a servant, attendant, messenger, officer, minister (B36AB). OI *ferg* = anger, wrath; a warrior (RIA F). Gaelic *fear-ogha* = grandson (Dw425A). Latin *Notivo* is a form of L *Noto* *-are* (*notatus -a, -um*) = to mark, write (C397A).

**Conclusion:** In my study of Rhys's photo, I saw IP BVAH QATTI DONATI VIIRGAMIIBO NOTIVO and accept Rhys's conclusion that the two parallel lines denote an E. Thus, IP BVAH QATTI DONATI VERGAMEBO NOTIVO. I am not convinced that IP and BVAH should be disregarded and suggest *Ip Buadha Catti donati—Vergamebo notivo* = (Stone) of the son of Buadha of the Catti, Donatus [A Gift]—Vergameb wrote (on it). OG *Buadha* could be a woman's name. L.A. Waddell held that *Catti* (*Qatti*, *Khatti*) was a tribal name. He claimed that it designated a ruling group of early Britons which had ancient connections with the civilizations of the eastern Mediterranean (specifically, the Hittites, who called themselves *Khatti* or *Catti* [referred to as *Chatti* or *Hatti* by the Assyrians and on Egyptian inscriptions as well as in the bible]). Waddell noted the presence of coins in pre-Roman Britain (perhaps second century BC) which bore the name CATTI. I agree with Rhys that Vergameb (or Vergamiib) is probably a name, perhaps Pictish.



Fordoun -- after Padel & MacAlister

**Datab. No.:** 6023

**Site:** Fordoun, Kincardineshire, Scotland

**Type:** Sepulchral

**Description:** This slab was found leaning against the wall in the ruins of the chapel of St. Palladius in the graveyard of Fordoun parish church, Auchinblae. It measured 5 feet 3 inches by 3 feet 4 inches and 4 inches thick. It bears two inscriptions one uncial and one ogham as well as an ornamental cross, Pictish symbols and carved horsemen. The uncial inscription is carved in two lines in half-uncials of a slightly different form from those shown in the font used below (but there is no doubt about the transliteration). Below, uncial line 2 is incorporated with line 1. According to Padel, the stone is no longer in St. Palladius' chapel, but in the church of Fordoun beside it (in the village of Auchenblæ).

**Uncial Line:** *rurtesī pidarnoin*

**Transliteration:** RURTESI PIDARNOIN

**Cognate Lang.:** Ruir-tess ip Eidir-noin

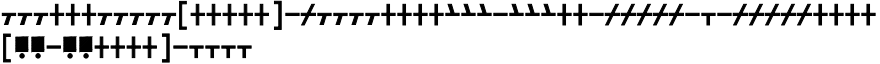


**Translation:** Ruir-tess, the son of Eidir-noin.

**Comment:** Rhys was unable to make out line 1, therefore his reading of line 2 is suspect. MacAlister read: RURTES (I)P IDARNONIN and equated IDARNONIN with EDDARRNONN of the Scoonie Stone (see #6019). He further suggested that IP is an abbreviation of IPE. MacAlister claimed that -es was a feminine ending so that RURT was therefore a woman's name. By the time Padel got around to this inscription, the first line was no longer legible. Jackson and Stevenson both place this inscription in the 8th century. Padel agreed that the second line was PIDARNONIN.

**Vocabulary:** OI *Ruiri* (*ruire*) = king, supreme ruler; knight, champion; lord (Dw777B; RIA R117). OI *Tess* = south; in the south (RIA T157). Welsh *Ap* (*ab*) = son of (E1A). OI *Eidir* = *Eighre* (*oigre*, *eiger*, *eigir*, *oigir*, *eidre*) = heir, inheritor, successor, descendant (RIA E79). OI *Nán* (*noin*) = small, dwarfish (RIA N13).

**Conclusion:** I suggest that IP or IPE might be a form of the Welsh *Ap* (*ab*) = "son of" (E1A), a component of so many Welsh surnames (*Ap* Ross, etc) (see IP on the Greenloaning Stone). I read: RURTES IP IDARNONIN = "Ruir-tess, the son of Eidir-noin." Ruir-tess would thus mean "Lord of the South" or "Southern Lord." Eidir-noin could mean "Small Heir."

**Ogham Line:**   
**Transliteration:** VUN[I]MSETTORBRE[(DD?)E]N  
**Cognate Lang.:** Wynnum sæta oir Bre(d?)en  
**Translation:** Wynnum, a resident of Brai(d)on.

**Comment:** As MacAlister pointed out, the ogham is very difficult, being quite worn and cut in very small scores on face of the left edge (rather than the corner) of the rather coarse-grained stone. Rhys was unable to make anything out in the Ogam inscription. MacAlister got VUN[...MSETTORBR(or N)[...E?..]N. Padel was unable to see an Ogham inscription on this stone, although he gives the uncial one. Forsyth does not list this one --at least not under the site name given here.

**Vocabulary:** AS *Wyn(n)* (*wynnum*) = delight, pleasure; a delight, that which causes pleasure; the best of its class, the pride of its kind (joyous); a personal name. (B1285A). AS *Sæta* = resident, inhabitant (apparently occurs only in compounds such as Dor-sett, for instance) (B812A). G *Air* = On, upon, of, concerning, for, on account of, by with (Dw17B). Oir can also be Or.

**Conclusion:** I tend to accept MacAlister's reading, but have inserted a possible double D in the last word of the inscription because, in studying the place names near Fordoun, I noted Braidon Bay which could possibly reflect an earlier Braidon or Brae Dun or Breden. Thus I get *Wynnum sæta oir Bre(d?)en* = Wynnum, a resident of Brai(d)on. It would seem that this originally Pictish monument has been used by later Celts to commemorate two or their own, perhaps at different times: Ruir-tess the son of Eidir-noin and Wynnum of Braidon.

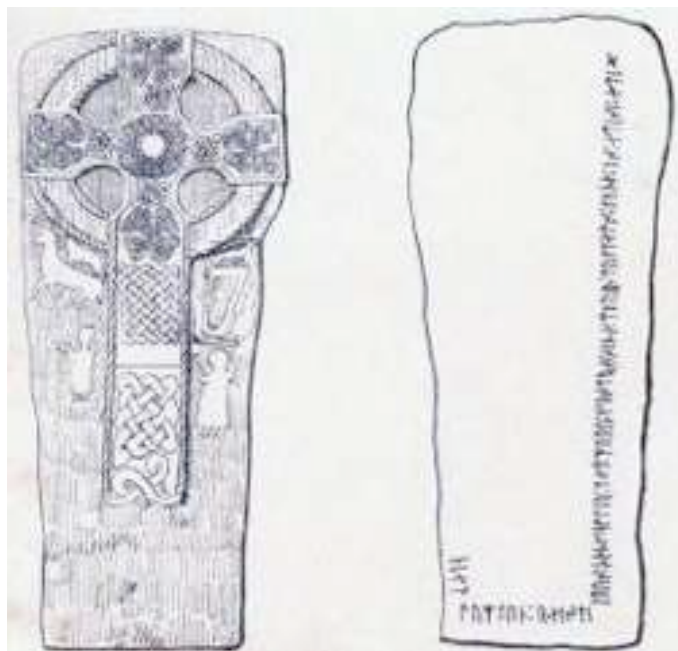


Image of Kirk Michael III from Wikipedia

**Datab. No.:** 6024  
**Site:** Kirkmichael, Isle of Man  
**Type:** Sepulchral

**Description:** The following is from the *Isle of Man Guide* Website: "A large slab carved in low relief on one face, showing a shafted cross with limbs connected by a circular ring. Shaft and circle have a cable border evening below in the head and tail of a serpent. In the centre is a ring of chain cable. The limbs contain triquetras in continuous bands. Below are plaits of nine and seven.

"To the left of the shaft is a hart sized by a hound and a robed Ecclesiastic with left arm raised in prayer and the right hand resting on a crutch shaped staff. At the other side, a hart and hound and man seated playing on a harp and robed figure holding a drinking horn. This must be one of the Valkyriur making an offering to Bragi, god of poetry and inspiration. Below the harper is another Ecclesiastic with arms uplifted in blessing with his right hand holding up a crutch headed staff. Below the cross and to the right has been scored the Ogam alphabet, related to the faint inscription on the middle, back of the stone, but it cannot be deciphered.

"Runes running up one side of the back translate as, Mal, Lumkun, krus, thena, efrer, Mal, Muru, fustra, sine, totir Tufkals, kona, is, athisl, ati. Meaning Mael Loncheu raised this cross to the memory of Mal Mura his foster (mother) daughter of Dugal the wife whom Athisl had. On the left the following reading has been done in the same hand, Betra, es, laifa, fustra, kuthan, than, son, ilan. Meaning Better is it to leave a good foster son than a bad son."

**Ogham Line:** **##[++++]-++++//++//++++++-++++++**  
**Transliteration:** G[E?]ERCADDSDEN  
**Cognate Lang.:** Gearr Cádós Dun  
**Translation:** Engraved for Catto's (Grave-) Mound.

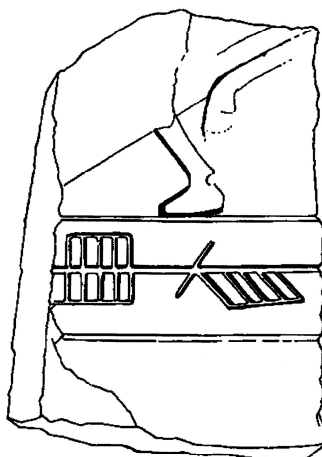
**Comment:** This artifact is sometimes called "Michael III. An Ogham alphabet is carved on the front of the cross. On the back is the badly eroded Ogham inscription shown here, along with the Runic inscription described above.



**Vocabulary:** G *Geàrr* (Early Irish *Gerr* = to cut, engrave (Dw485B; McB192). OI *Cáid* (*cád*, *cato*, *catto*) = holy, noble, pure (RIA C23). G *dùn* (*dùin*; AS *dún*) = heap, hill, mound; hill, fortified house; fortress (grave) (B218B; Dw373B; RIA D449).

**Conclusion:** I get: G[E?]ERCADDOSDEN = *Gearr Cáddos Dun* = Engraved for *Catto's* (Grave-) Mound. This stone bears (on the other side) a runic inscription relating to one Mal-Lomcom. That inscription has been discussed previously under its other name: Michael 3. At that time I had not made the connection between the Michael 3 inscription and the badly abraded Ogham inscription known as Kirkmichael. This connection was pointed out to me by a colleague, Lawrence Athy, who had his own ideas about the translation of some of the Ogham inscriptions. Padel felt the ogham was indecipherable. The translation of the runic tells us that this stone was a cross raised by Mal-Lomcom for his foster-mother, Mal-moro. It is clear that there is little or no relationship with the Ogham inscription on the other side which was cut at a different time (probably later than the Runic, but it could be earlier). In a previous publication I suggested that the runic inscription was "as late as the 12th or even the 13th century" on the basis of the "stung E." It is noteworthy, however, that a stung E in an inscription might occur as early as 1050, thus putting it in the mid-11th century. Thus we can conjecture that the Ogham probably was not added before the late 11th or early 12th century (putting it nicely on a par with other instances of "scholastic Ogham" occurring in the British Isles.

Allen/Anderson/1903, Fig. 323 (after Forsyth)



Abernethy

**Datab. No.:** 6025  
**Site:** Abernethy, Perthshire, Scotland  
**Type:** Sepulchral  
**Description:**

**Ogham Line:** **|||||/+++++**  
**Transliteration:** ...(MAC?)QMI...  
**Cognate Lang.:** ...(Mæ)cg (?) Mi...  
**Translation:** ...(So)n (?) of Mi...

**Comment:** This is quite fragmentary and, according to Padel, too small to be of any linguistic value. The stone was discovered in 1890 by a Mr. Marr of Abernethy, Perthshire (Southesk 1895:245, cited by Forsyth). It comes from "a house in Station Road" according to Dugal Butler (as quoted by Padel). Apart from the ogham, the only other carving is the leg of a horse in relief. Rhys saw -IMN- or -QMI-. Macalister saw IMN. Padel stated that the letters are very clear and "there is no doubt about the reading although it could be in either direction." Padel noted that "the

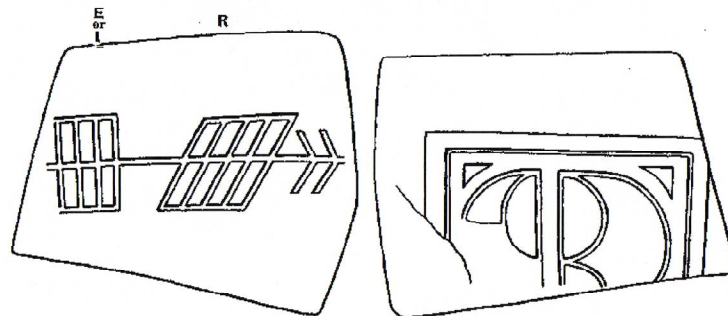
letters are very unevenly spaced...in other respects...the carving is fairly careful" and "the presence of bind-oghams...practically unknown in Irish oghams." Finally, he remarked: "...the slope of the five stroke consonant is such that we are compelled to read the inscription from right to left (however unlikely this may seem) if it is associated with the fragment of a picture. The only alternative is to postulate that the ogham ran vertically..." Padel reads QMI ("or, if taken improbably in the other direction, IMN"). Katherine Stuart Forsyth reported extensively on this inscription in an unpublished PhD paper in 1996. Another ogham that was reported to exist in Abernethy is fairly certain to be a forgery, according to Padel.

**Vocabulary:** AS *Mæcg* = man, disciple, son (H224A). AS *Mæg* (*mag*) -es = a relative, a kinsman; male kinsman, parent, son, brother, cousin; can also be a female relation, a wife (B654A; H224B). AS *Maga* = a son, descendant, young man, man (H228A). OI *Maccu* (*moccu*) = belonging to the family (gens) of (RIA M10). OI *Mac* (*macc*) = a son; a male descendant (RIA M5).

**Conclusion:** QMI is correct. I read it as (MAC?)Q MI = ...(Mæ)cg (?) Mi... = ...(So)n (?) of Mi.... Padel is correct in his statement that it is too fragmentary to be of any linguistic use. Forsyth's suggested reconstruction in her PhD dissertation is excellent (F10c).

Allen/Anderson/1903, Fig. 11.

Cunningsburgh I (After Forsyth)

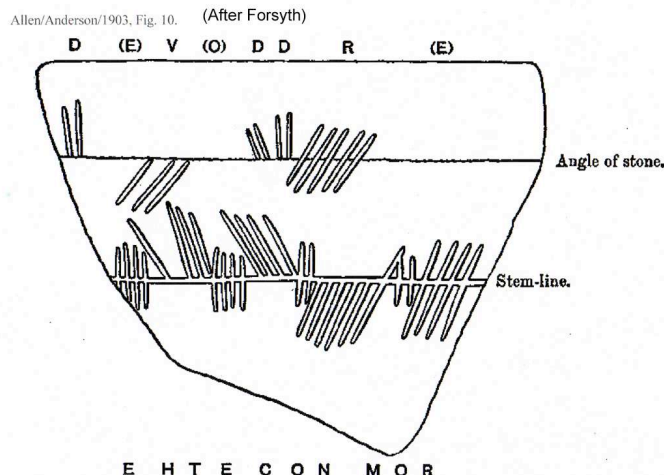


**Datab. No.:** 6026  
**Site:** Cunningsburgh I, Shetland, Scotland  
**Type:** Sepulchral  
**Description:**

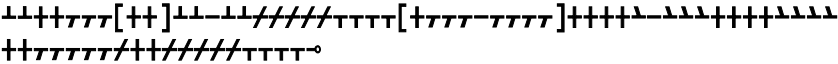
**Ogham Line:** ++++++/////[[+++]  
**Transliteration:** -IR(U?)-  
**Cognate Lang.:**  
**Translation:**

**Comment:** Rhys got IR or RI. MacAlister read IR(U?). Nicholson saw ...IRU... and suggested [T]IR U... = "Land of O..." Padel read it IRU. Forsyth saw -]l( /d/h)R(u/e)[-.

**Conclusion:** I agree with the reading IRU. It is too fragmentary to translate.



**Datab. No.:** 6027  
**Site:** Cunningsburgh II, Shetland, Scotland  
**Type:** Sepulchral  
**Description:** Forsyth says that this stone, a triangular fragment of grey sandstone, was probably found in 1874 or 1875 'close by the burying ground' by Rev. George Clark.

**Ogham Line:** 

**Transliteration:** DOVODDRS... (AVN?)EHTECONMORS  
**Cognate Lang.:** Domh Oddr-s... (af) (n)eachd Con mors  
**Translation:** Odd's House [or mausoleum]... (of) the great tribe of Conn.

**Comment:** This incorporates line 2. This is Rhys's Cunningsburgh I. He saw it in 1897 when he got: EHTECONMOR(or F)[SA(or VI)]. Rhys noticed another line of Ogam on the same stone which he read D(or QU)[U or E]V[O or U]DDRS. Nicholson got DETODDRE(V) EHTECONMORR = *d'et Oddre'v ehte Con Morr* = *d'ait Odraibh aite Con Mho(i)r* = At hearthside Grays, hearthside of Cu Mor. MacAlister read: DEV...ODRS... EHTECONMOZS. Padel read ...EHTECONMO(RS or ZN) ...D(O or U)V... (D or O)DRS... Forsyth saw EHTECONMORS. Forsyth's reading is shown in the graphic. The differences in the various readings lie in the vowels inserted by the several scholars involved.

**Vocabulary:** OG *Domh* (pronounced "dov"; OI *dom* from L *domus*?) = house, home (Dw351A; RIA D333). ON *Oddr* = a point of a weapon, the front; a leader (a proper name and a component of proper names) (V462B). G *Neach* (OI *Nech*) = Person, any person; one, someone (Dw686B; RIA N17) and Old G  lic *Neachd* = Tribe, Family; Pledge (Dw686B). OG *Con* (*conn*) = reason, sense, meaning (Dw249A; Dw250B). G *Con* = wolf, dog (Dw249A) G *M  r* = great, large, important (Dw670B).

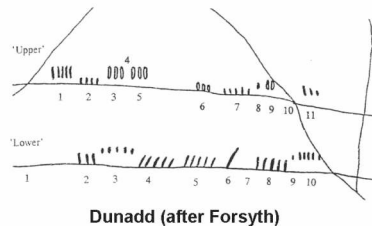
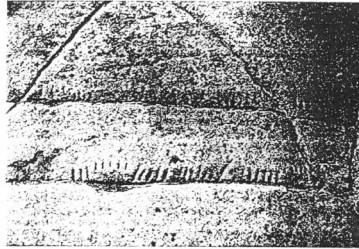
**Conclusion:** I get DOVODDRS...(AVN?)EHTECONMORS = *Domh Oddrs...(af) (n)eachd Con mors* = Oddr's House (in the sense of mausoleum or a grave).. (of) the great tribe of Conn. I follow Padel's reading of DOV rather than DEV. It is what I noted from the drawing he shows —and, besides, it makes a great deal more sense in the context than DEV. It is also possible to read this as "Oddr slumbers (here)," since DOV has that connotation, but in this instance "domh"—also pronounced "dov"—seems to give the best reading and is supported by the fact that the proper name, *Oddr*, is rendered as a possessive. Here, again, we have an intermixture of Teutonic and Celtic words buried in a basically Anglo-Saxon grammatical structure. The reference to the tribe of Conn is interesting. We have just such a Celtic tribe noted, not only in Ireland ("—the Half of Conn"), but also in Southwest Portugal ("—a warrior of the Conn").

**Datab. No.:** 6028 (Graphic unavailable at this time)  
**Site:** Cunningsburgh III, Shetland, Scotland  
**Type:** Sepulchral  
**Description:** According to Forsyth, the stone, unearthed in the churchyard at Cunningsburgh in the Spring of 1903, is a thin parallelogram fragment of micaceous sandstone incised with three



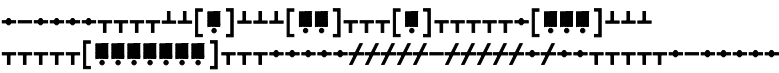
**Ogham Line:**   
**Transliteration:** ...NNDAR...  
**Cognate Lang.:**  
**Translation:**

**Comment:** Padel got: (V or S or N)NDAR. Forsyth got -(v/s/n)N(:d)AR[?] and also suggested a reversed reading as a possibility. Forsyth suggested RAQQI (reading from the right) and NARR (from the left). I suggest (...N)NDAR... It is too fragmentary to attempt a translation.



**Datab. No.:** 6031  
**Site:** Dunadd, Argyllshire, Scotland  
**Type:** Sepulchral?

**Description:** Forsyth says: "The fortress of Dunadd (*Dun Ad*)... is situated on an isolated rocky hilltop ... above the flood plain of the meandering Add, 6 km. north-west of Lochgoilhead." She reported the following concerning the inscription's location: "Just below the summit ... is a flattish terrace of bare rock riven with fissures and bearing a number of carvings" (including the ogham inscription above). She added: "Even if the strokes of the inscription were known locally, they were not recognized as an inscription by the scholarly community until attention was drawn to them in 1953 by Stewart Cruden of the Ancient Monuments Inspectorate." Kenneth Jackson published his account of the inscription in 1965.

**Ogham Line:**   
**Transliteration:** AESD.T..V.NA....TU.. L.... VIRRAMONAI..  
**Cognate Lang.:** Æs d(a?)t(i)v(a) na(nci)tu(r)... L(ughaidh?),vir ab Monæ...  
**Translation:** Alloted wages received... L(ughaidh?), a man (or soldier) from Mona (the Isle of Man).

**Comment:** This inscription is horizontal without stem lines on a flat bare rock surface near the top of a fort. It may be associated with other carvings a few feet away: a footprint, a boar and a cup-shaped hollow. It is in two lines (both shown here, following Padel's version), the second line beginning with the "L." Athy stated that it has no strokes which can in any way be interpreted as vowels and only three showing the long slanting strokes indicating they belong to the "M" group. Jackson read HCSD. T.. V. NH. T for the 1st line and L.... VQRRHMDNHQ for the second line on p. 182 of his book, but does not show the Ogham. Padel noted that many of the "consonants" look slightly more like vowels (of an Irish type—being nicks, not long scores) and got: AESD..T...V..(N or L or V)A..TV and L....VIRR(H or A)MDNAI. Katherine Stuart Forsyth reported

extensively on this inscription in an unpublished PhD paper in 1996. She got, for the first (upper) line: (ae/i/q)S(d/o)(u/at/i/q/e/c)[---]V( /a/o)(n/lv)A( /d/o)[crack](t/ch/v). For the second (lower) line she got: FI(nn/rr)MaNA(ch/q).

### Vocabulary:

*Æs* = money, wages, a soldier's pay, reward (LS60Cff). L *Dativus* (-a,-um) = of or belonging to giving, given, appointed (LS512C). L *Nancitor* (also *nancitur*) from *Nancio* = to get, obtain, gain (receive) (LS1185Cff). L *Vir* (*vir* fr. Skt. *vira* = hero) = a man, a soldier (LS1994C). L *A* (*ab*) = from, out of, by, at, in (LS2Aff). L *Mona* (-æ) = the name of two islands: the Isle of Man, in the Channel between Ireland and Britain, and the Isle of Anglesey, part of Wales (LS1160C).

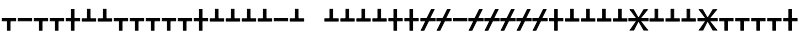
**Conclusion:** My reading is essentially the same as Padel's, but I suggest that the D in the second line is actually intended to be an O and the final V is really a U. I propose the name "Lughaidh," (a suitably Celtic name), but of course it could have been any other male name beginning with an L (Leif, a Norse name, for instance). While *Vira* could be read as "woman," it is believed that the apparent -a ending is actually short for the word "*ab*" = "from" and that the person memorialized is a man, probably a soldier who served in the fort at Dunadd. If this kenning is even close to correct, one wonders if this might be a macabre joke on the part of the carver—that this is, indeed, a sepulchral monument, a soldier's ultimate wage being death.

**Datab. No.:** 6032 (No graphic is available at this time)

**Site:** Kilgubin East, Kerry Co., Ireland

**Type:** Sepulchral

**Description:** MacAlister said this (his #1086 in CIIC) was found near Ardfert in Co. Kerry, in Ireland. He described it as "a lamp in the form of a hanging bowl, made of a light-coloured brass-like alloy. . . It is now in the National Museum, Dublin." He added that ". . . the vessel is in the form of an inverted pyramid with rounded angles. The sides of the triangular mouth are each 9 [and three-quarter] inches long, and the height of the triangle which they form is a little over 8 inches. The lip of the opening is everted. The depth of the vessel is 3 [and one quarter] inches. There is a looped handle attached to the outer surface of each of the three sides, prolonged downward to a tail secured with a rivet."

**Ogham Line 1:** 

**Transliteration:** BLADNACH COGRACETENA

**Cognate Lang.:** Blæd-nac cóc ræced-ena

**Translation:** Bladnach, the Cook of the Palace

**Comment:** This is the first part of a two line inscription. The inscription "BLADNACH COGRACETENA" in scholastic Ogam with incised stemlines is on one side of the lip of the vessel. On the opposite side, on the downward prolongation of the handle, is "BLADNACH CUILEN" (see Inscription No. 6033). The vowels are expressed by long vertical scores (except for 'E' which is expressed by the X-mark). So far as I have been able to determine, Forsyth does not mention this inscription.

### Vocabulary:

ON *Blað* (AS *blæd*) = blade, leaf, leaf-like objects; blade of an oar or a sword ("sword-blade" is thought of by some as being a somewhat modern usage); in AS also carries the meaning: a cup, bowl, goblet. There is a possibility for a good pun here, for in AS *blæd* can also = breath, life, spirit, mind, animus; enjoyment, prosperity, abundance, success, blessedness, gift, reward, benefit; glory, honor (V66B; B107A). AS *Naca* = boat, bark, ship, vessel (B706A). AS *-neah* (*ge-neah*) = sufficiency, abundance (B420B, 711A). ON *Nægð* = plenty, abundance (V460B). ON *Nægja* = to be enough, suffice (V460B). AS *Nacod* (Germ. *nackt*) = naked (B706A). AS *Neah* = nigh, near (B710B). OI *Nach* = *nech* = one, anyone, someone, a person (RIA N4f, N17f). OI *Nach* = neg. adv. 'not'; rel. particle introducing neg. 'who not' or 'who does not'; conj. introd. subordinate negative clause 'that...not' (RIA N5f). It is possible that the ON *Ne* (cognate w/German *noch* and Latin *nec*) = a negative conj. 'not' might have resumed its harsh ending







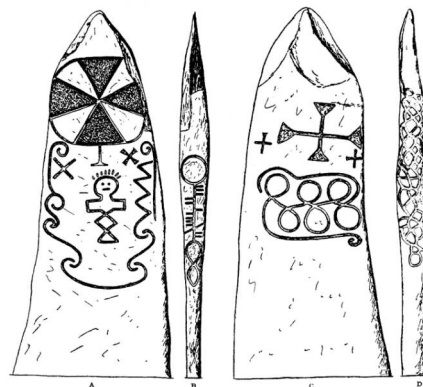
Sometime prior to 1929 the stone was removed from the wall and placed on a concrete base just inside the narthex of the church where I saw it in May 1982. Unfortunately, several letters (in brackets, above) are now concealed in the concrete base in which it was seated, but luckily they were clearly recorded in the early reports. MacAlister saw the stone in 1915 and reported on it in 1916, 1929, and in his *Corpus Inscriptionum Insularum Celticarum* in 1949.

The High Cross form of the Killaloe stone dates it no earlier than the 9th or 10th century AD. The use of a stung rune indicates a date no earlier than the middle of the 11th century (and more likely early 12th) AD. We note that the Killaloe church was destroyed by fire seven times between 1015 and 1155. It is probable that during one of the reconstructions, this cross fragment from its attendant cemetery was used to build a wall. It is Buchanan's opinion that a date in the late 11th or early 12th century is mandated (in 1993 he suggested early 13th might be possible, but now feels that to be a bit late). J.S. Marstrander suggested a date for the Killaloe stone of sometime between 1015 and 1081, but did not elucidate his reasoning. Buchanan feels, however, that his dates are not unreasonable.

### Vocabulary:

AS *bén* (gen. dat. *béne*; acc. *bén*) = a blessing, a praying, a prayer, petition (B83A). OI *beandacht* = a form of *bennacht*, the Old Irish version of the Latin *benedictum* or *Benediction* = "a blessing" (the Ogham X-marking represents either an "e" or an "ea" —in the Gælic it is *beannacht* and has also been seen as *beandacht*, *bendachta* and *bendacht* (RIA B77). AS *Dóhtar* (*doghtor*; ON *dóttir*) = daughter (B206A; V102A). OI *Ar* (*air*) = the prep. for, on (RIA A366). *Toroqrim* = a Celt (or a person of Scandinavian descent whose language has been influenced by immersion in a Celtic environment) attempting to spell *Thorgrim*. Apparently he heard more of a "k" sound than a "g" sound. The "g" is clear from the Runic inscription and Thorgrim is a known Norse name.

**Conclusion:** It is important to note that, unlike most Ogham inscriptions in Ireland, the Killaloe Ogham is engraved in the manuscript, not the lapidary, style. MacAlister notes others in the manuscript style: the cross-slab from Glenfahan, County Kerry, and the slab of Colman Bocht at Clonmacnois. Both lines of the Ogham inscription are shown here. There is also a Runic inscription reading *þurgrim risti krus áina* = Thorgrim carved this cross. Both the Runic inscription and the Ogham inscription were deciphered by me in my article: *An Enquiry into the Dating of Certain Celto-Scandinavian Inscriptions in the British Isles* which was published in *ESOP*, Vol. 22, p. 148 (1993). I originally accepted (1993) the previous translations which gave a Celtic cast to the inscription, deriving the Oghamic language from Old Irish. With new insight, however, that the presence of scholastic Ogham may mask a language with an Anglo Saxon base I suggest a possible alternate reading in Celtic-influenced Anglo-Saxon: *Ben dóhtar Toroqrim* = [Let there be] a prayer for the daughter of Thorgrim.



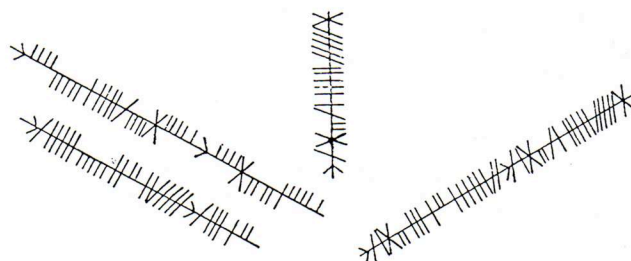
Glenfahan —After R. A. S. Macalister

**Datab. No.:** 6035  
**Site:** Glenfahan, Kerry Co., Ireland  
**Type:** Sepulchral?  
**Description:** A slab 4'5" x 1'9" x 0'5", found by officials of the Board of Works engaged in repair work on the ancient structure called *Caher Murphy*, one of a series of stone huts on the southern slope of Mount Eagle. (MacAlister)

**Ogham Line:**   
**Transliteration:** LMCBDV (up) [TLHSMD (down) --after shift: BREOSI]  
**Cognate Lang.:** Breas-i]  
**Translation:** Belonging to Breas

**Comment:** Reported on in the 1893 *Proceedings of the Royal Irish Academy* (PRIA) by the then Inspector of Ancient Monuments, Sir Thomas Deane. It is MacAlister's No. 183. A slab, 4'5"x 1'9" x 0'5" found by the officials of the Board of Works while repairing the ancient structure known as Caher Murphy, one of the large series of stone huts on the southern slope of Mount Eagle in the Barony of Corkaguiny in County Kerry. On one edge are Ogham letters on an incised stemline with a loop at one end (the top) and double infinity loops at the other (the bottom). McCallister noted that the M is sloped in the wrong direction (when reading from the bottom) and provided an excellent drawing. Reading from the bottom, he got LMCBDV. Since he regarded it as indecipherable, he believed it probably had some magical purpose.

**Conclusion:** The use of the Scholastic Ogham format and the decorations (which remind one of the so-called "Pictish" stones) suggests that the subject for whom the stone was made (or, at least, the carver) may have resided in Scotland at one time. This is a cryptic inscription. One is intended to read it from the single circle down towards the double circle. This gives us TLHSMD. This still makes no sense. There is a further step in the encipherment. Each letter represents one 13th after it (or 7th before it) in the Ogham alphabet. This gives us BREOSI, which would be a genitive form of OldGaelic *Breas* (*bres*) = a Celtic personal name (often born by mythological or legendary characters) which means, according to Dwelly, as a noun, "prince, king, hero, chief;" and as an adjective, "illustrious, eminent, great, mighty" (Dw 120A; GPN 35; RIA B 179). O'Corráin and Maguire, in *Gaelic Personal Names* show *Bress*, *Breas* (br'as) = a masculine name which could mean "shapely, beautiful" or "fight, uproar, din." It seems to be always borne by mythological or legendary characters in Irish literature. The most famous of these is Bress mac Elathan of the Tuatha dé Danann. It is probably the main element in the names *Bressal*, *Breasal*, *Bressalán*. Thus BREOSI = *Breas-i* = "Of Breas" or "Belonging to Breas." M. A. O'Brien in his *Corpus Geniologiarum Hibernae* lists at least five genealogies containing *Bress* (*Breisse*), undoubtedly a form of *Breas* (I also found three such mentions among the heros in T. W. Rolleston's *Myths and Legends of the Celtic Race*). See a similar possibly cryptic inscription from Ardywanig in Co. Kerry.



Ballyspellan, Co. Kilkenny, Ireland  
 (After MacAlister)

**Datab. No.:** 6036  
**Site:** Ballyspellan, Kilkenny Co., Ireland  
**Type:** Dedicatory  
**Description:** A silver penannular brooch (c. 9<sup>th</sup> century AD), found in 1806 by a peasant digging in the ground on the hill of Ballyspellan. On the reverse sides of the triangular expansions ,which terminate the ring of the brooch, there are four lines of writing in Scholastic Ogham.

**Ogham Line:**

**Transliteration:** CNAEMSEaCH CEaLLACH  
 MINODOR MUAD

**Cognate Lang.:** Cnáimsech Cellach  
 Mineadair Muad

**Translation:** Cellach the Midwife  
 Muad the Mealman

**Comment:** The first two lines of a four-line inscription. This artifact, a silver penannular brooch or fibula (MacAlister's #27) was found in Sep. 1806 in Co. Kilkenny, Ireland, by a peasant digging in the ground on the hill of Ballyspellan on the farm of Charles Byrne (Lord Ashbrook's estate, Barony of Galmoy). MacAlister reported that it had been placed in the collection of the Royal Irish Academy. Brash reported on it in his book (p. 289ff). It is a fine example of ancient Celtic personal ornament. The face is richly ornamented in the Irish style. On the back are four lines of Ogham characters very neatly engraved in the "scholastic" style, three on the left side of the back and one on the right. MacAlister, on the basis of the style of its decoration, dated it to about the 9th century AD. George M. Atkinson, however, who edited Brash's book (and who made the sketch of the artifact for Brash's book—recorded elsewhere in this database), felt that the brooch was of 12th century workmanship. Of the three lines on the left side, two slant downwards from left to right (and read in that direction) being roughly parallel; and one is perpendicular, reading bottom to top. The line on the right side slants upwards from left to right (and reads left to right). We are here considering the two 'parallel' lines first as if they were one line and the single vertical second along with the single line on the right side (see following page).

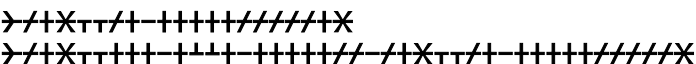
MacAlister, Brash and Atkinson agree that the four lines refer to the names of successive owners of the brooch. O'Curry is reported to have identified the name Cnaemsech in a genealogy in the Book of Lecan (but, on checking, MacAlister found that the name given there was Cnaimside). MacAlister and Brash pointed out that the word *cnaemsech* (*cnaimhseach*; *cnaimhsech*) means "midwife" according to K. Meyer in *Contributions to Irish Lexicography*. *Ceallach* is well known as a name and Brash noted that *Minodoir* signifies "a mealman." He correctly read *Muad* as "noble, good."

#### Vocabulary:

OI *Cnáimsech* (from *cnaim* = bone, body) = midwife (RIA C265). G *Cellach* (*Ceallach*) = bright-headed? (a personal name which can be male or female, but mostly male) (GPN49). G *Mineadair* = Mealman (Dw658A). OI *Muad* (G *muaidh*) = adj. Noble, good; shapely, well-formed (appears in personal names) (RIA M177; Dw674B).

**Conclusion:** *Cellach* is clearly a personal name. M. A. O'Brien has numerous references to genealogies containing it (Obr.538ff). *Cnaimsech* does not appear as a personal name at all—nor does *minodor* or *mineadair*. *Muad*, on the other hand, is a known name-component and could be a name by itself (GPN139). I disagree with MacAlister and Brash and suggest "*Cellach* the Midwife" and "*Muad* the Mealman"—this despite the fact that words descriptive of an individual (in this case a vocation) normally appear after the personal name. Perhaps these first two lines were written at the same time and may memorialize the wedding between *Muad* (the Mealman) and *Cellach* (the Midwife). The next two names (see next page) are probably respectively their child and grandchild. I tend to agree with Atkinson and date this artifact to the late 11th and early 12 centuries. It was probably fashioned in the late 11th century and passed down through the

generations in the early-to-mid 12th century. MacAlister, however, dated it to the 9<sup>th</sup> century on the basis of the style of the decorations on the artifact.

**Ogham Line:**          
**Transliteration:**    MAEaLMAIRAEa  
                              MAEaLUADAIG MAEaLMAIREa  
**Cognate Lang.:**    Mael-Mara  
                              Mael-Uadaich (mac) Mael-Mara  
**Translation:**        Belonging to Mael-Muir  
                              Belonging to Mael-Uad, (son of) Mael-Muir.

**Comment:**        MacAlister recognized *Mael-maire* as a name, but could not find an example of it in the records. Brash was not so finicky, suggesting that it was a form of the common name *Mael-Muir*. Neither could find originals for *Mael-Uadaig*, but both noted the occurrence in the records of a similar name, *Mael-Uidir* (*Mael-Uidhir*; *Mael-Uidhar*).

**Vocabulary:**    OI Mael (G maol) = crop-headed, shorn (as a monk or a young boy); blunt, hornless, headless; bare; servant, slave, devotee; the component of a number of Celtic male (rarely female) names: Mael Anfaid, Mael Coluim, Mael Duin, Mael Eoin, Mael Maedoc, Mael Morda, Mael Muad, Mael Muire, Mael Odran, Mael Ruanaid, etc. (RIA M18ff; Dw629B; GPN129). OI Muir (as. muire; ds. muir; gs. moro, mora, mara; G gs. mara) = the sea, the ocean (RIA M193; Dw678B; T190, ¶300). MI Ai (OI aui; as. uith, gs. uath or uad [T gives these as gpl.]; ds. uaidh) = f. n. poetic inspiration or art; metrical composition; learning (RIA A88; T206, ¶323).

**Conclusion:**    I agree that *Mael-Maire* is a name. *Mael-Maire* or *Mael-Mara* is the genitive of *Mael-Muir* (the genitive singular of *Muire* or *Muir* in OI would be "*moro*," "*mora*" or "*mara*"—latter also seen in Gaelic). Here it indicates possession. *Mael-Muire* was probably the son of *Cellach* and *Muad*. The name means "Servant of the Sea" or "Devotee of the Sea." Although Ireland was largely Christian at the time this name was given, it would appear to reflect a dedication to a sea god. Perhaps its ancient meaning had been forgotten by the the parents who gave him his name and it was given simply because they liked it. According to Brash, one *Mael-Muir* (*Maelmuiri*, *Maelmuire*) was a noted scribe in *Clonmacnoies* (this must be a typo for *Clonmacnoise*) in the 12th century AD. *Clonmacnoise* was a famous abbey and school of learning which was founded c.541/4 AD by *Ciaran*, the son of an artificer (Br.80, 85, 323f). It was an early center of Christianity, located in Co. Offaly, Ireland. The abbey was laid waste by the English in 1552. Note that Co. Offaly (King's) is only two counties over from KilKenny. Since the artifact was probably made in the late 11th century and passed down from father to son to grandson, it is possible that the *Mael Muir* who owned it during his lifetime and passed it on could have been the very same famous scribe of the 12th century just noted. It would seem that a bit of genealogical work here might pay dividends. The *Corpus Genealogiarum Hiberniae* (Vol. I) by M. A. O'Brien contains references to the descent of six persons named *Mael Maire* (note that these names for the most part come from a 12th century Oxford manuscript). None of these individuals show the proper parents, however, to agree with our *Mael-Muir* here.

*Mael-Uad* is obviously also a name. *Uad* is the genitive singular of *ai* and means "of learning." The meaning of the name is thus "Servant (or Devotee) of Learning." The carver treated the name as a unit and added the genitive *-aich* or *-ach* (here rendered *-aig*) to give the sense "of (belonging to)." *Mael-Uad* was the son of *Mael-Muir* and the last of record to own the brooch.

**Datab. No.:**        6038  
**Site:**                Clonmacnois, Offaly Co., Ireland  
**Type:**               Sepulchral  
**Description:**



